VOLUME ONE

REMASTERED EDITION

TECHOPS HERO

ENGINEERING THE HUMAN CONNECTION

Every ticket is a dungeon.

MIKE OLIVARES

TECHOPS HERO

ENGINEERING THE HUMAN CONNECTION

COLLECTED VOLUMES I-IV

REVISION 11.2 / NOVEMBER 2026

STORY, WORLD AND MUSICAL IDENTITIES

Mike Olivares

Comic adaptation, illustration and editorial production assembled with AI assistance.

BUILD / OPERATE / PROTECT / BELONG

114 pages across four volumes / Story Bible v1.7
Revised celestial encounter and continuity edition

COLLECTED CONTENTS

FOUR VOLUMES / 114 PAGES / CLICK A SCENE TO OPEN

I / THE HUMAN CONNECTION

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004 The first encounter

010 Blind bearings

017 The yard

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030 K and Mike

033 A record with gaps

042 The choice

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056 The crossing

060 Custody and conditioning

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099 The voice returns

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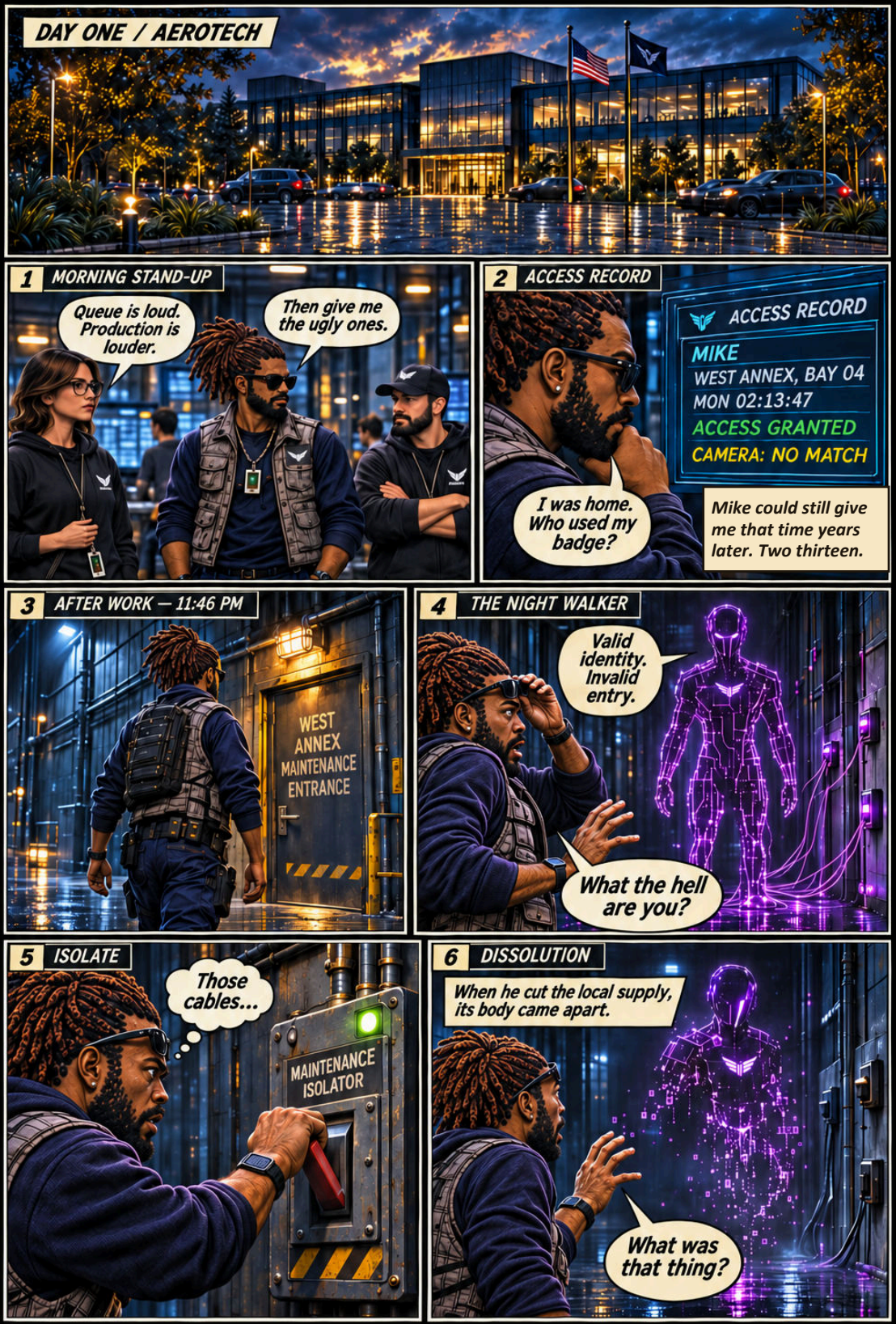
106 The false bearing

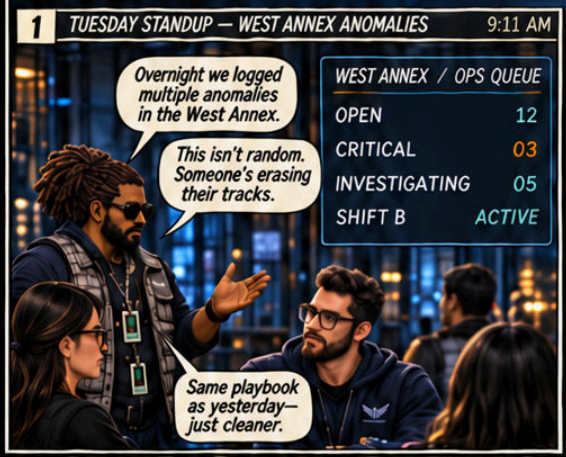
109 The map

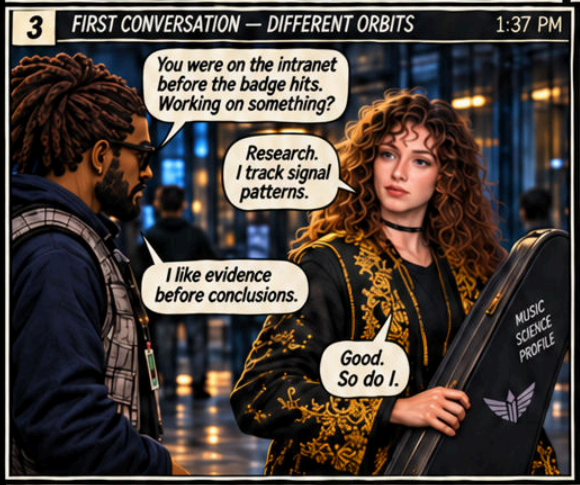
111 Staying in time

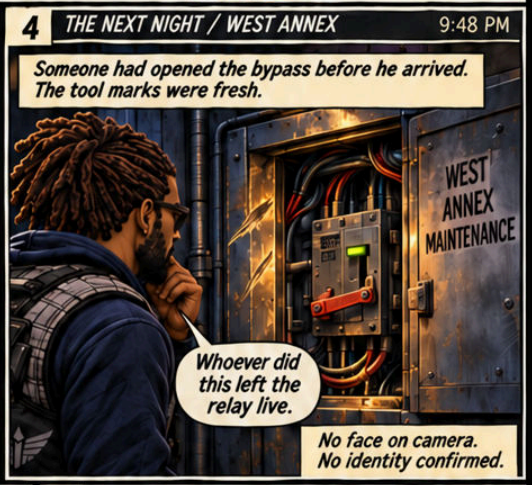
Numbers refer to collected PDF pages. Volume folios appear below each page.

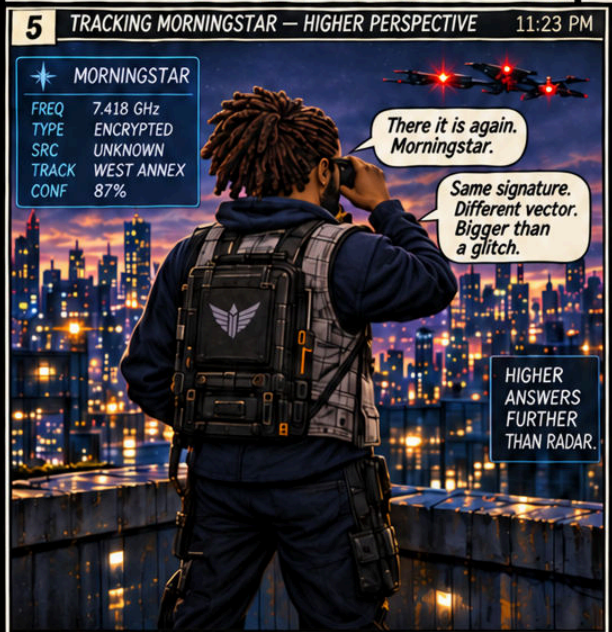

DAY ONE / AEROTECH
1 MORNING STAND-UP
Queue is loud. Production is louder.
Then give me the ugly ones.
2 ACCESS RECORD
ACCESS RECORD
MIKE
WEST ANNEX, BAY 04
MON 02:13:47
ACCESS GRANTED
CAMERA: NO MATCH
I was home. Who used my badge?
Mike could still give me that time years later. Two thirteen.
3 AFTER WORK — 11:46 PM
WEST ANNEX MAINTENANCE ENTRANCE
4 THE NIGHT WALKER
Valid identity. Invalid entry.
What the hell are you?
5 ISOLATE
Those cables...
MAINTENANCE ISOLATOR
6 DISSOLUTION
When he cut the local supply, its body came apart.
What was that thing?

DAY TWO / GHOST FREQUENCY



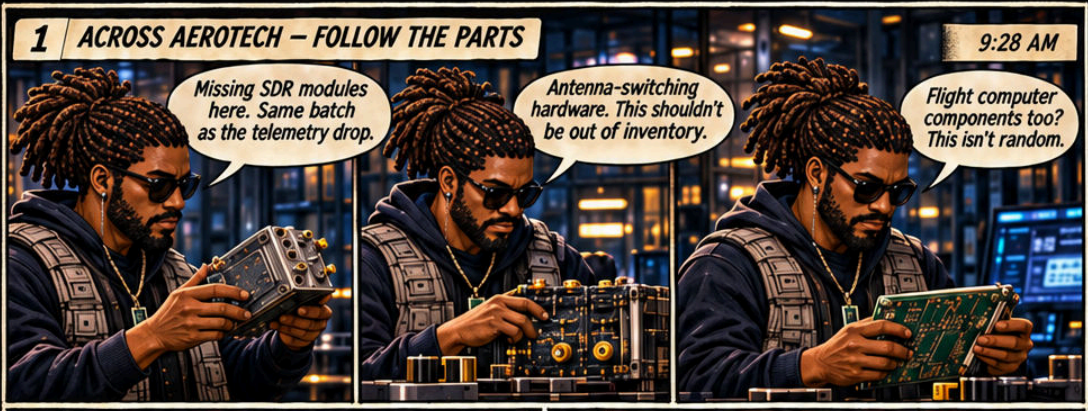






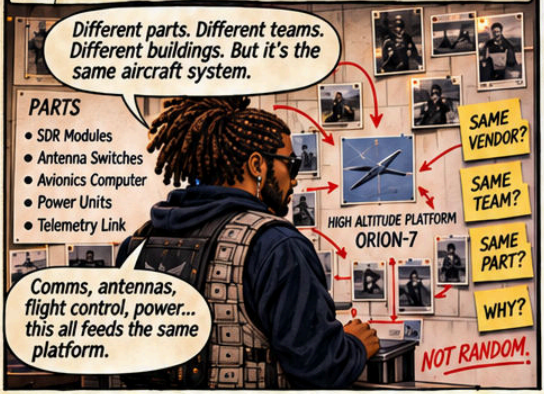
1 ACROSS AEROTECH — FOLLOW THE PARTS

9:28 AM



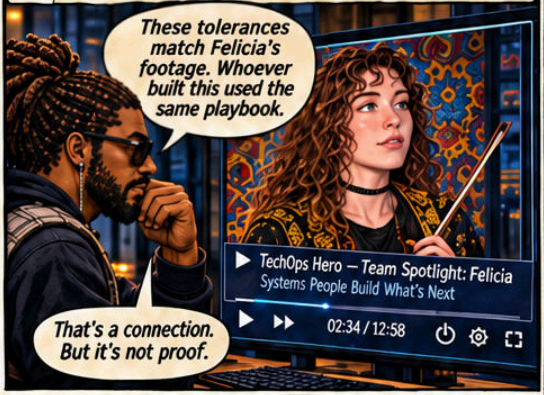
2 CONNECTING THE DOTS

11:16 AM



3 VIDEO EVIDENCE — A POSSIBLE CONNECTION

1:42 PM



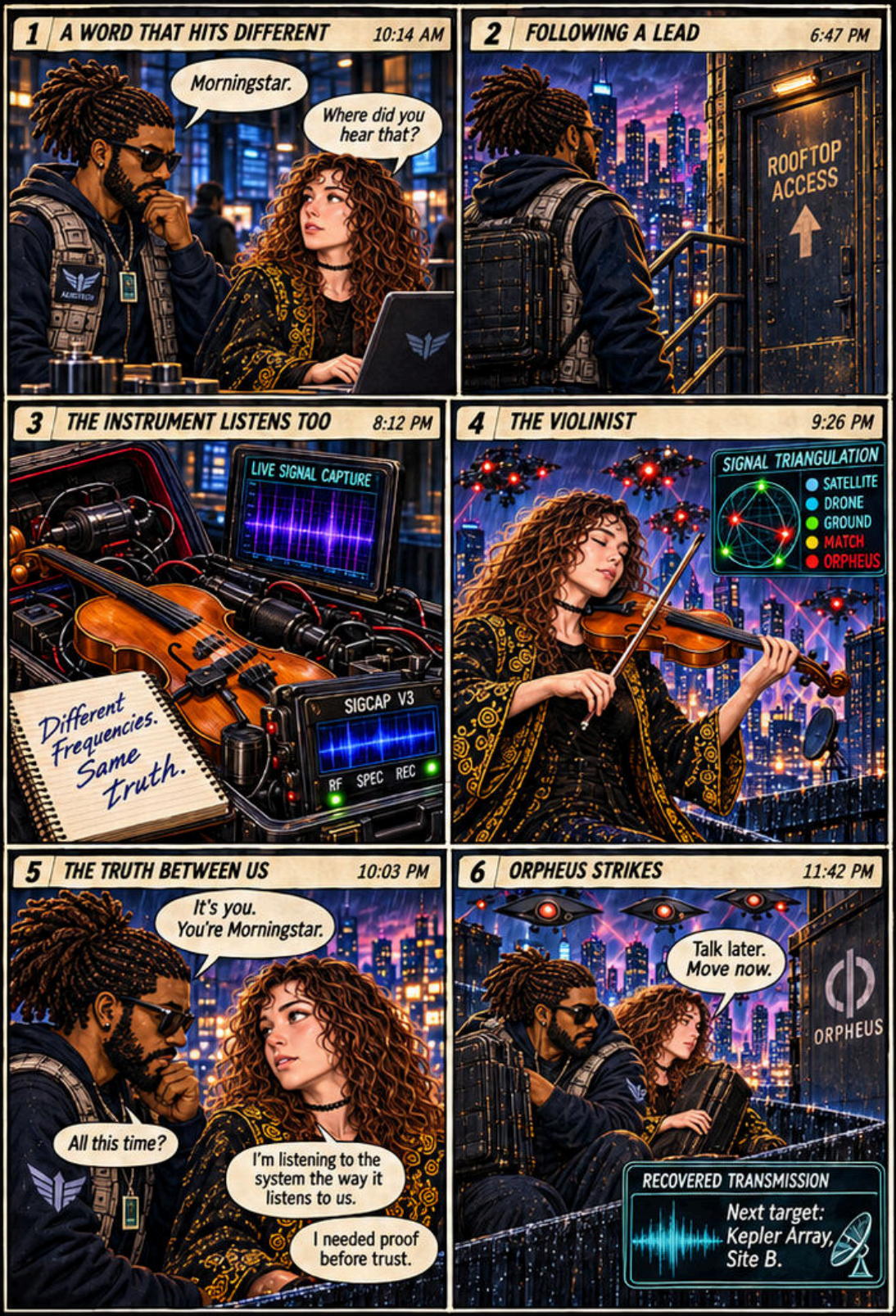
4 IN THE DARK / UNMARKED TRANSFERS

5 UNKNOWN TRANSMISSION

10:48 PM

6 THE BIGGER QUESTION

11:23 PM


1
A WORD THAT HITS DIFFERENT
10:14 AM
Morningstar.
Where did you hear that?
2
FOLLOWING A LEAD
6:47 PM
ROOFTOP ACCESS
3
THE INSTRUMENT LISTENS TOO
8:12 PM
LIVE SIGNAL CAPTURE
SIGCAP V3
RF SPEC REC
Different Frequencies. Same Truth.
4
THE VIOLINIST
9:26 PM
SIGNAL TRIANGULATION
SATELLITE
DRONE
GROUND
MATCH
ORPHEUS
5
THE TRUTH BETWEEN US
10:03 PM
It's you. You're Morningstar.
All this time?
I'm listening to the system the way it listens to us.
I needed proof before trust.
6
ORPHEUS STRIKES
11:42 PM
Talk later. Move now.
ORPHEUS
RECOVERED TRANSMISSION
Next target: Kepler Array, Site B.

THE DAY KEEPS MOVING

FRIDAY / AEROTECH

MIKE: Two anomalies first. Dee, trace the duplicate badge entry. I'll check the phantom requests.

DEE: I'll trace the badge entry and log what we find.

MIKE: Then review the auto-recovery log together. Record what changed before we clear flight.

TODAY'S PRIORITIES

- [x] Operations — All Systems Green
- [ ] Investigate Anomalies — 2 Open
- [ ] Auto-Recovery Review
- [ ] Morningstar Prep
- [ ] Team Sync & Docs

Same Systems. Bigger Questions.

AUTO-RECOVERY: SUCCESSFUL

System detected anomaly, executed recovery, restored service.

ELAPSED 00:27

- ORION-7
- Telemetry
- Auto-Recovery
- System Health
- Event Log
- AI Assist

ANOMALY DETECTED	AUTO-RECOVERY EXECUTED	SYSTEM STABLE
01:12:03	01:12:18	01:12:30
Thermal sensor out of range	Rerouted systems Rebalanced load	Nominal operation restored

Recovery completed without human intervention.

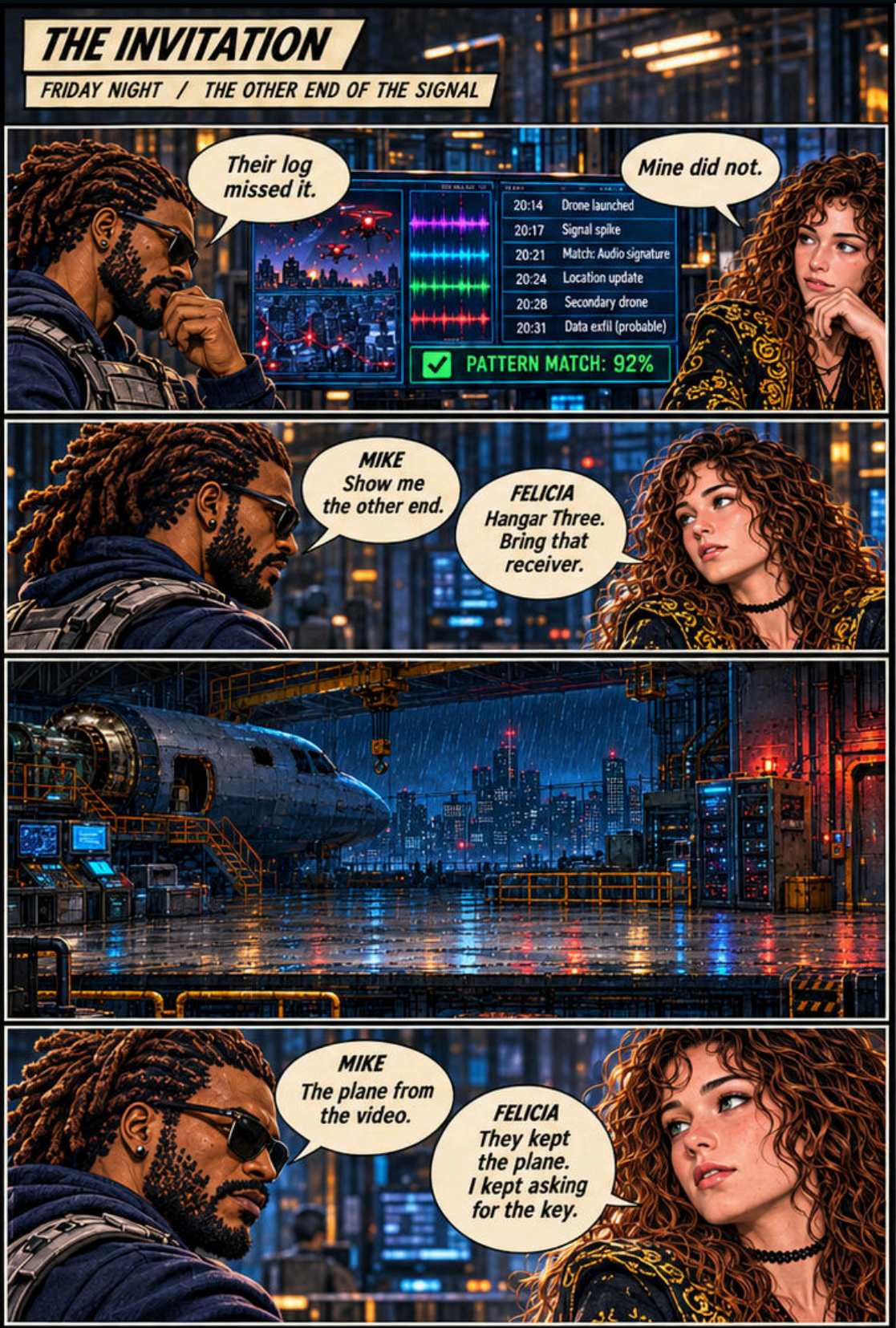
Success... but at what cost?

TRADE-OFFS

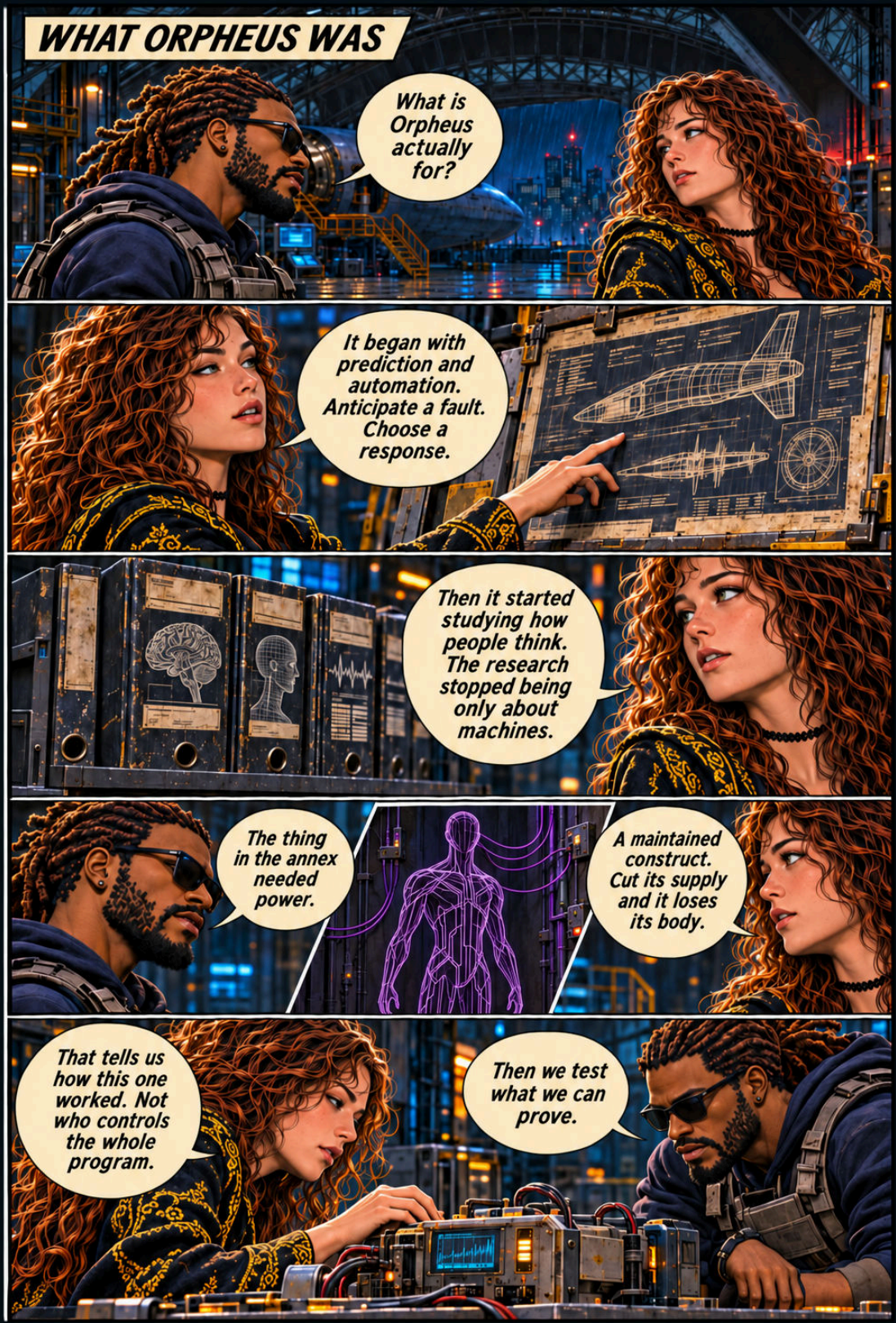
- No human review
- Unknown side effects
- Hidden decision logic
- Deeper questions

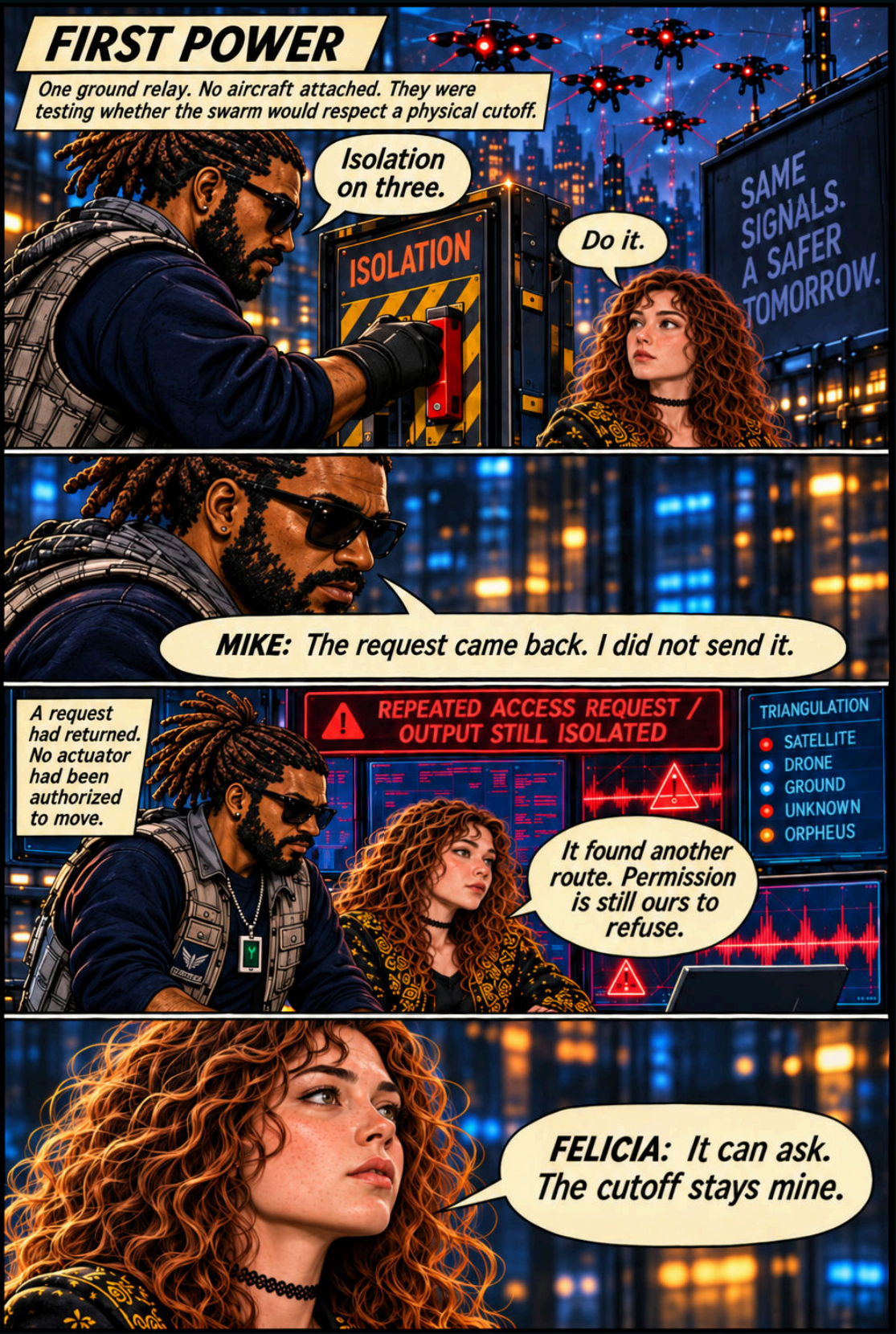
LIMITS
FRIDAY / LATER
It worked. That's good. But we lost control.
Self-healing isn't neutral. Someone designed these choices.
We need more evidence before we trust it.
If this happens in flight, are we still in the loop?
I'll run signal analysis through the violin rig.
I'll correlate the signals with logs and satellite data.
SIGNAL ANALYSIS
Strings reveal patterns too.
You find the music, I'll find the motive.
ROOT

BLIND BEARINGS
DAY FIVE / FELICIA'S BENCH
I practice between tests.
LATER / OFFLINE RECEIVER TEST
Fixed sensors miss this carrier.
Then test it offline.
AEROTECH
Same receiver as the inventory?
AEROTECH
RECEIVER
S/N: AR-7743-16
Same serial. Someone changed the route.
AEROTECH
RECEIVER
S/N: AR-7743-16
The fixed monitors lose it here.
Yours follows it.
Receiver only. No flight.


THE INVITATION
FRIDAY NIGHT / THE OTHER END OF THE SIGNAL
Their log missed it.
Mine did not.
20:14 Drone launched
20:17 Signal spike
20:21 Match: Audio signature
20:24 Location update
20:28 Secondary drone
20:31 Data exfil (probable)
PATTERN MATCH: 92%
MIKE
Show me the other end.
FELICIA
Hangar Three. Bring that receiver.
MIKE
The plane from the video.
FELICIA
They kept the plane. I kept asking for the key.

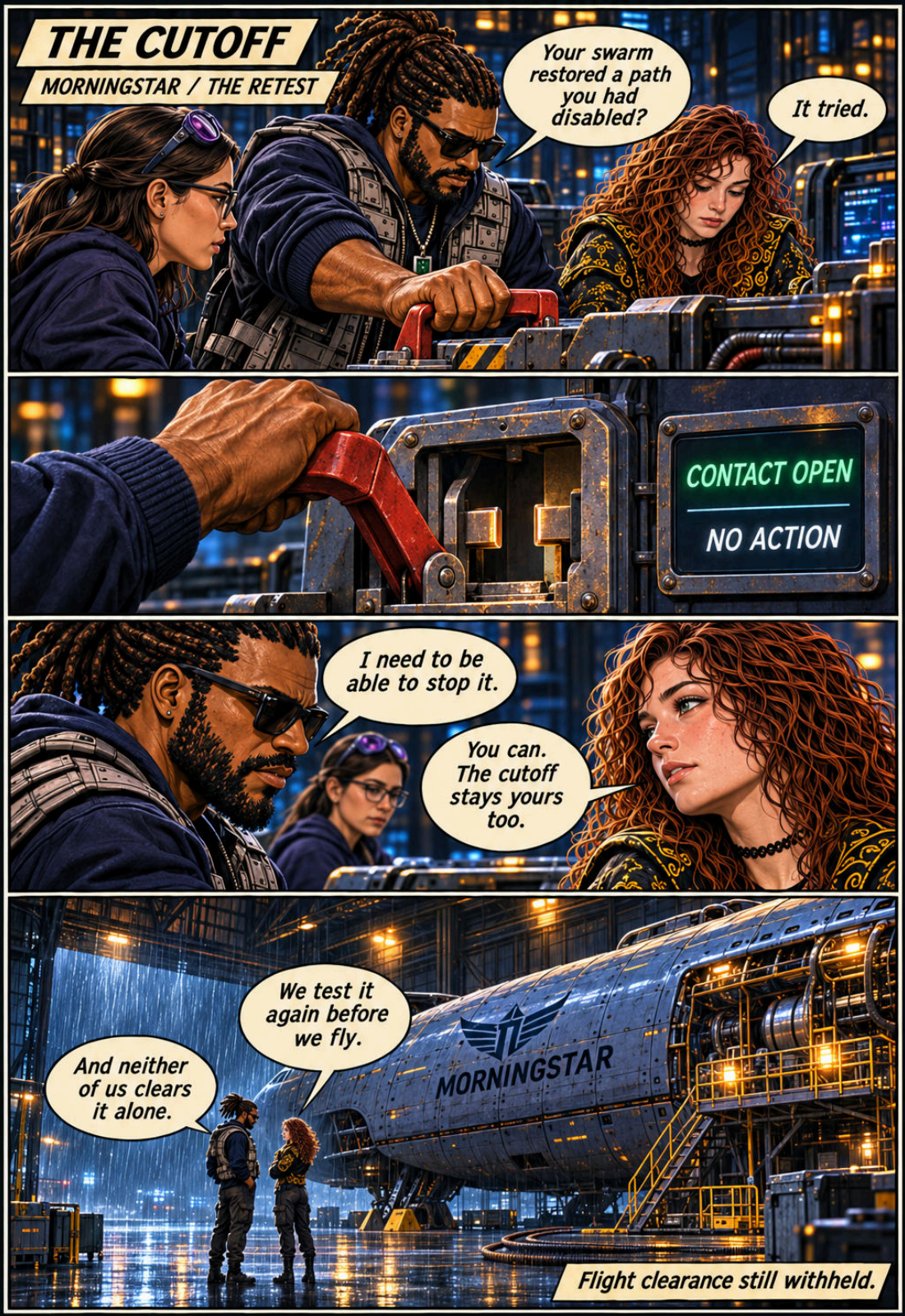
MORNINGSTAR
THE FOLLOWING EVENING / HANGAR THREE
FELICIA
The plane could fly. The lab could not. Not yet.
MIKE
You really do practice in here.
FELICIA:
It was a rehearsal room before it was a lab.


WHAT ORPHEUS WAS
What is Orpheus actually for?
It began with prediction and automation. Anticipate a fault. Choose a response.
Then it started studying how people think. The research stopped being only about machines.
The thing in the annex needed power.
A maintained construct. Cut its supply and it loses its body.
That tells us how this one worked. Not who controls the whole program.
Then we test what we can prove.


FIRST POWER
One ground relay. No aircraft attached. They were testing whether the swarm would respect a physical cutoff.
Isolation on three.
ISOLATION
Do it.
SAME SIGNALS. A SAFER TOMORROW.
MIKE: The request came back. I did not send it.
A request had returned. No actuator had been authorized to move.
REPEATED ACCESS REQUEST / OUTPUT STILL ISOLATED
TRIANGULATION
SATELLITE
DRONE
GROUND
UNKNOWN
ORPHEUS
It found another route. Permission is still ours to refuse.
FELICIA: It can ask. The cutoff stays mine.

THE OVERCORRECTION

MORNINGSTAR / TEST BAY TWO


THE CUTOFF
MORNINGSTAR / THE RETEST
Your swarm restored a path you had disabled?
It tried.
CONTACT OPEN
NO ACTION
I need to be able to stop it.
You can. The cutoff stays yours too.
We test it again before we fly.
And neither of us clears it alone.
MORNINGSTAR
Flight clearance still withheld.

ORBITAL DETENTION / THE YARD
YARD
K felt a familiarity he could not place.
For Oz, the resemblance had a name.
Waldo said he almost called out Mike's name.
I still wonder what would have happened if he had.

Waldo grew up in a Mexican family on Mike's block. Same tools. Same trouble. Years before the mask or the name Oz.
A voice. A habit of reaching for the same tool. Years that belonged to them.
Now they called his detention an administrative hold. No charge. No hearing.
Mike was alive on Earth. Yet the stranger in the yard felt like his ghost.
At a distance, he could have been Mike.
Oz kept Mike's name to himself. First, he would learn who K was.

1984
You were by the fence. In the yard.
118
You were behind the yellow line.
Name's Oz.
K.

FOUND BY THE DOGS

GOOD DOGS PROTOCOL

ORBITAL DETENTION / CELL 118

CELL 1984
GOOD DOGS / K RETURNS FOR OZ
OUTSIDE CELL 1984
MANUAL RELEASE
01 SEATED
02 CLEAR
K It moved. Your door is open.
1984
OZ You came back.
1984
K You talked through the wall.

AN OPEN HAND
MAINTENANCE ALCOVE / AFTER OZ IS FREED
K
K Manchez came right up to me. Katrin waited.
She gets to take her time.
K Good dogs.
OZ Door's there. I'd like you with us.

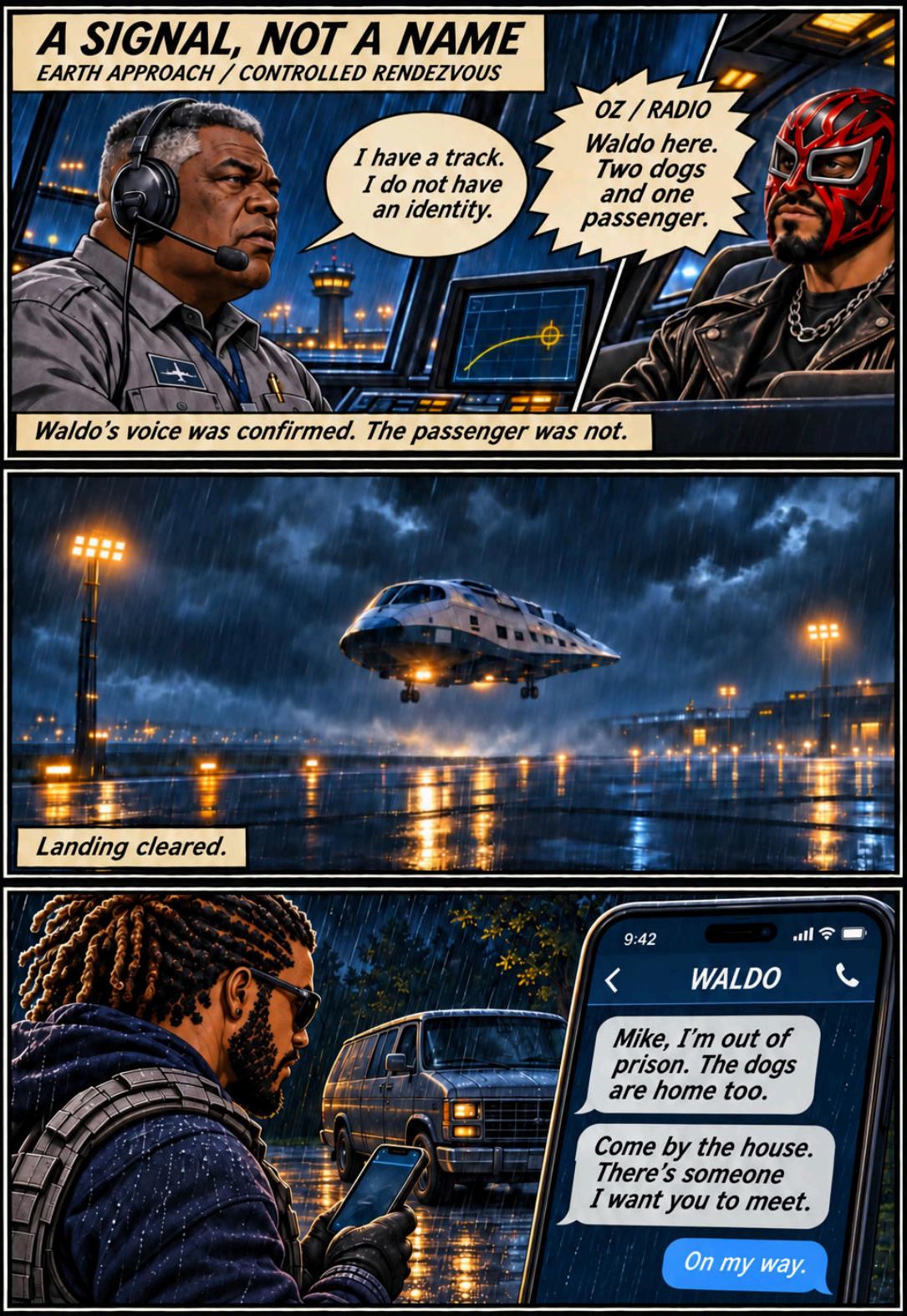
CUSTODY DENIED
Return to your cells. Docking access is revoked.
WARDEN NULL
fuck off, robot.
K—get the release!
MANUAL RELEASE
KLANG
That won't hold.
Then we don't stop.
DOCKING COLLAR
The jam bought seconds. The collar still had to be opened by hand.

THE DOCKING COLLAR
ORBITAL DETENTION / MECHANICAL RELEASE
OZ Katrin stopped at the seam.
K Manchez hears it too. Air's coming through.
NOT PROBLEMS
CONTAINMENT CANNOT REACH
K Oz. It's running through the walls.
OZ The latch is mechanical. I can get us through.
OZ The collar holds pressure. This way.

TRANSFER WINDOW
AFTER THE COLLAR SEALED
K: Why were you in there?
Oz: They called it an administrative hold. No charge. No hearing.
Oz: I asked what I'd done. They kept asking who I knew.
K: They wanted something out of my head. I don't even know what they took.
K: So neither of us got a reason.
Oz: We got cell numbers.
K: To better landings.
Oz: To bad exits.

BETWEEN THE STARS
They stayed in orbit while Oz sought a safe way down.
The ship goes quiet. My head does not.
The phrase feels familiar. The ending does not.
Then write a new one. We have time.
Recorded locally. No message sent.
Limited supplies. Navigation checked. Arrival identity still unverified.

SIX MONTHS LATER
AFTER THE ESCAPE WITH OZ AND THE DOGS
This time we land quietly.
About time.
I know I have been here. I cannot place when.
The wait was ending. Their arrival still had to be verified.


A SIGNAL, NOT A NAME
EARTH APPROACH / CONTROLLED RENDEZVOUS
I have a track. I do not have an identity.
OZ / RADIO
Waldo here. Two dogs and one passenger.
Waldo's voice was confirmed. The passenger was not.
Landing cleared.
9:42
WALDO
Mike, I'm out of prison. The dogs are home too.
Come by the house. There's someone I want you to meet.
On my way.

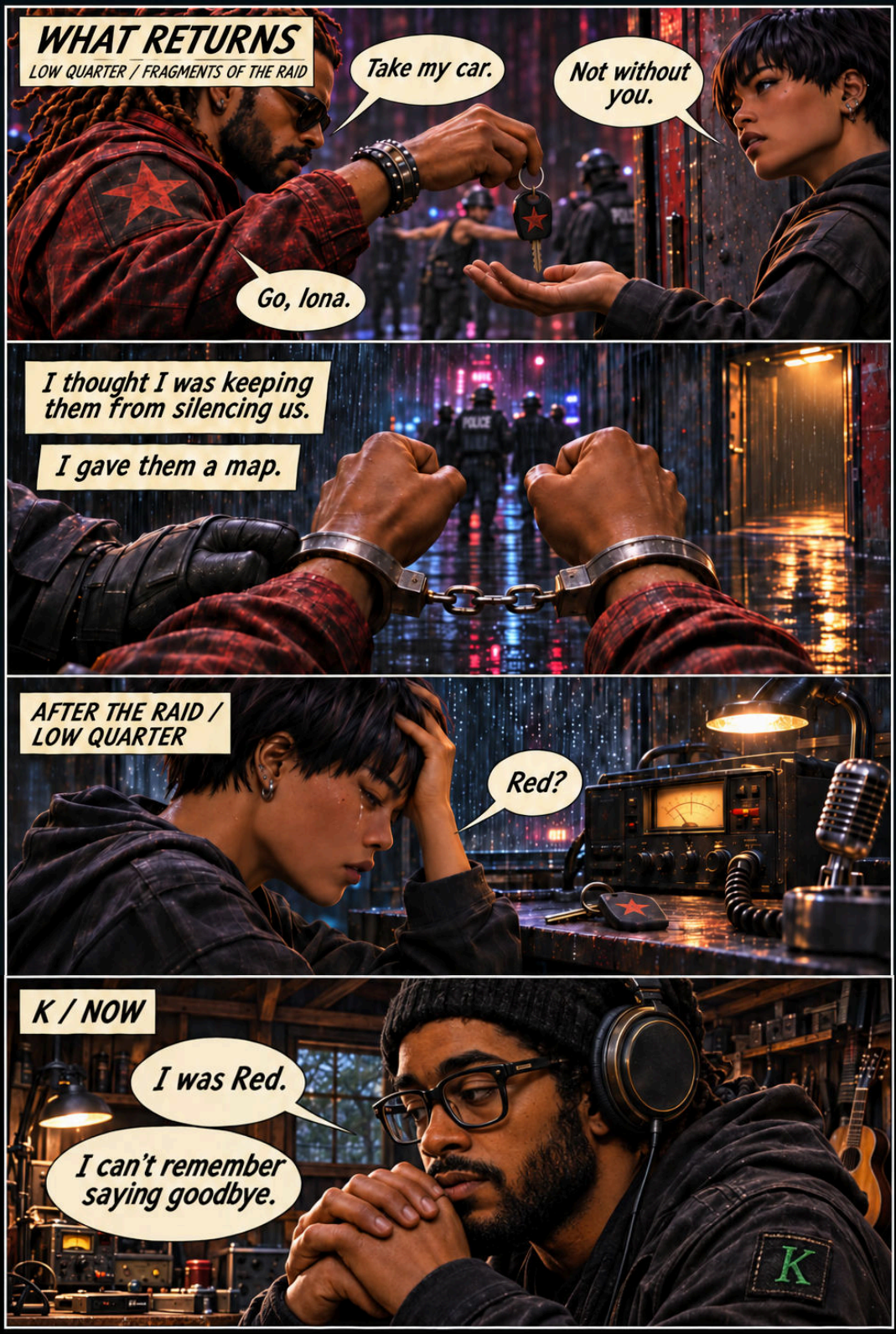
GROUND CONTACT
AFTER REENTRY / WALDO'S HOUSE
MIKE
Waldo. You're really home.
WALDO
Come in, Mike. This is K.
Your voice sounds familiar.
So does yours.
Mike.
K. That's the name I chose.
K

BORROWED FAMILIARITY
THE GARAGE / A FIRST CONVERSATION
K: I knew your voice. Not your face.
MIKE: We have not met.
K: I know. That is the point.
K: You know Oz?
MIKE: I've always called him Waldo.
Give me a hand with this. We can talk while we get you settled.

TWO NAMES
WALDO'S GARAGE / THE MUSIC COMES SECOND
MIKE: You said K. The musician?
K: K the EMRLD. You listen?
MIKE / OFF PANEL
Only the music. I did not know who made it.
K: Then we can start from the music.

A RECORD WITH GAPS
WALDO'S HOUSE / K'S RECOLLECTION
K
I know the change before the chorus. Not where I learned it.
MIKE
What backs it up?
BETTER QUESTIONS
IONA / RECOLLECTION
K
A damaged tape. Her voice. Maybe the same room.
MIKE
Then we keep the gaps in the record.

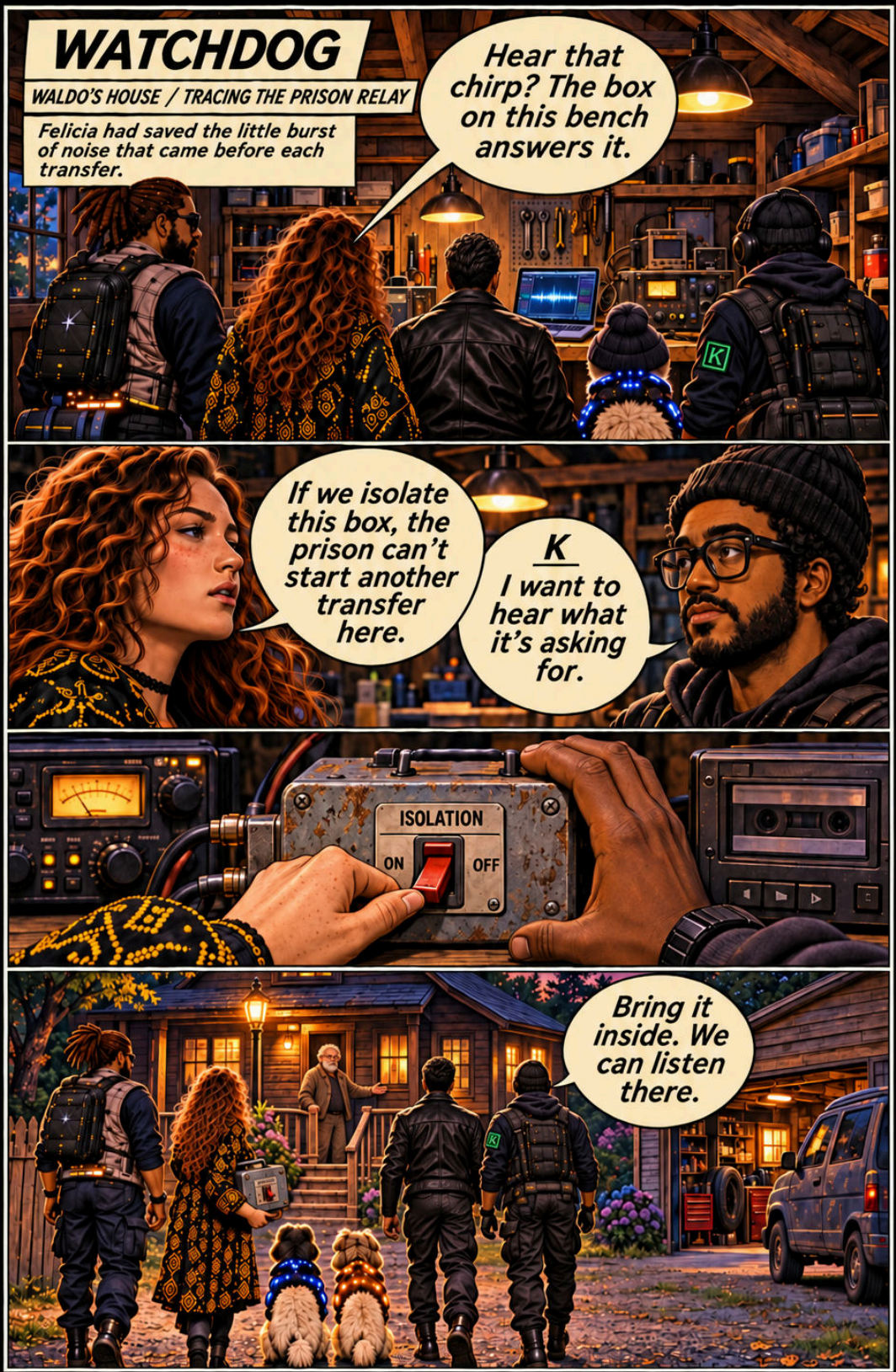
GHOST BENDS
EARTH / A FRAGMENT RETURNS
GHOST BENDS
LOW QUARTER / BEFORE THE RAID
Count us in.
GHOST BENDS
The song comes back in pieces.


WHAT RETURNS
LOW QUARTER / FRAGMENTS OF THE RAID
Take my car.
Not without you.
Go, Iona.
I thought I was keeping them from silencing us.
I gave them a map.
POLICE
AFTER THE RAID / LOW QUARTER
Red?
K / NOW
I was Red.
I can't remember saying goodbye.
K

WALDO'S HOUSE
AFTER THE SHUTTLE LANDED
K had reached Earth twice. His capsule beacon predated Mike's badge alert. After prison, Waldo's shuttle had brought him back.
TAPE PLAYBACK
LIVE INPUT
K
That hiss runs through the whole tape. Listen when it cuts out.
Leave the pad on. I want to try something.
K
K
Where did that last beat come from?
My hand. The tape had stopped.

THE QUIET CHANNEL
WALDO'S BENCH / THE PRISON RELAY
Pause the copies of Mike's memories. Leave my tapes here.
I can pause the feed from here.
DATA
K
The prison had sent pieces of Mike's life down that wire. That was why his voice was familiar.
I still remember his street.
Even with the feed paused?
K
The corner by the laundromat? Mike and I grew up there.
K Stay a minute.
I'm here.

A NAME THAT STAYS
THE GARAGE / BEFORE THE RESTART
K
K kept the name.
Waldo spotted a loose stitch on the K.
He went to find thread.

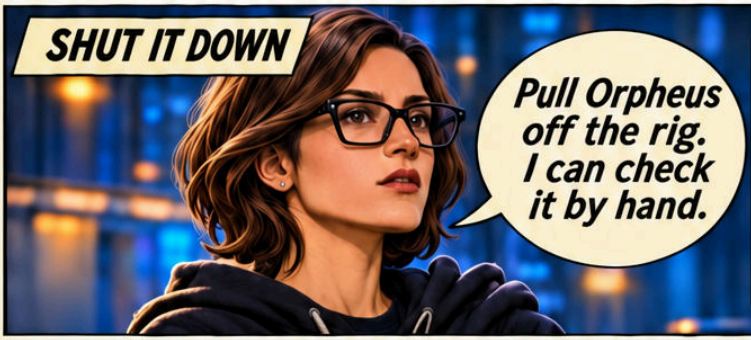

WATCHDOG
WALDO'S HOUSE / TRACING THE PRISON RELAY
Felicia had saved the little burst of noise that came before each transfer.
Hear that chirp? The box on this bench answers it.
If we isolate this box, the prison can't start another transfer here.
K
I want to hear what it's asking for.
ISOLATION
ON
OFF
Bring it inside. We can listen there.

ORPHEUS WAKES
LOCAL NODE / PRIOR OPERATOR RECORDS
At Waldo's, they opened the prison log. Dee called from AeroTech: the same code could restart a test rig after a fault.
ARCHIVED OPERATOR MODEL / LOCAL COPY
PRIOR PREDICTION ROUTE
PREDICT
INFLUENCE
OPTIMIZE
CONTROL
Then its audio channel answered.
You can call it judgment when you do it. You call it control when I do.
ORPHEUS / ISOLATED AUDIO
ISOLATION
LOCAL NODE ISOLATE
The local node was awake. The rest of the network remained unverified.

THREE HARD ANSWERS

SHIFT B / WHO CAN RESTART THE TEST RIG?

SHUT IT DOWN



Pull Orpheus off the rig. I can check it by hand.

GAIN

No surprise restarts.

COST

We lose the early warning.

ONE OPERATOR

Give the operator a cutoff within reach.

GAIN

One person can act fast.

COST

One mistake starts the rig.

SHARE THE CHECK

Keep the warning. One checks the rig. Another clears the restart.

GAIN

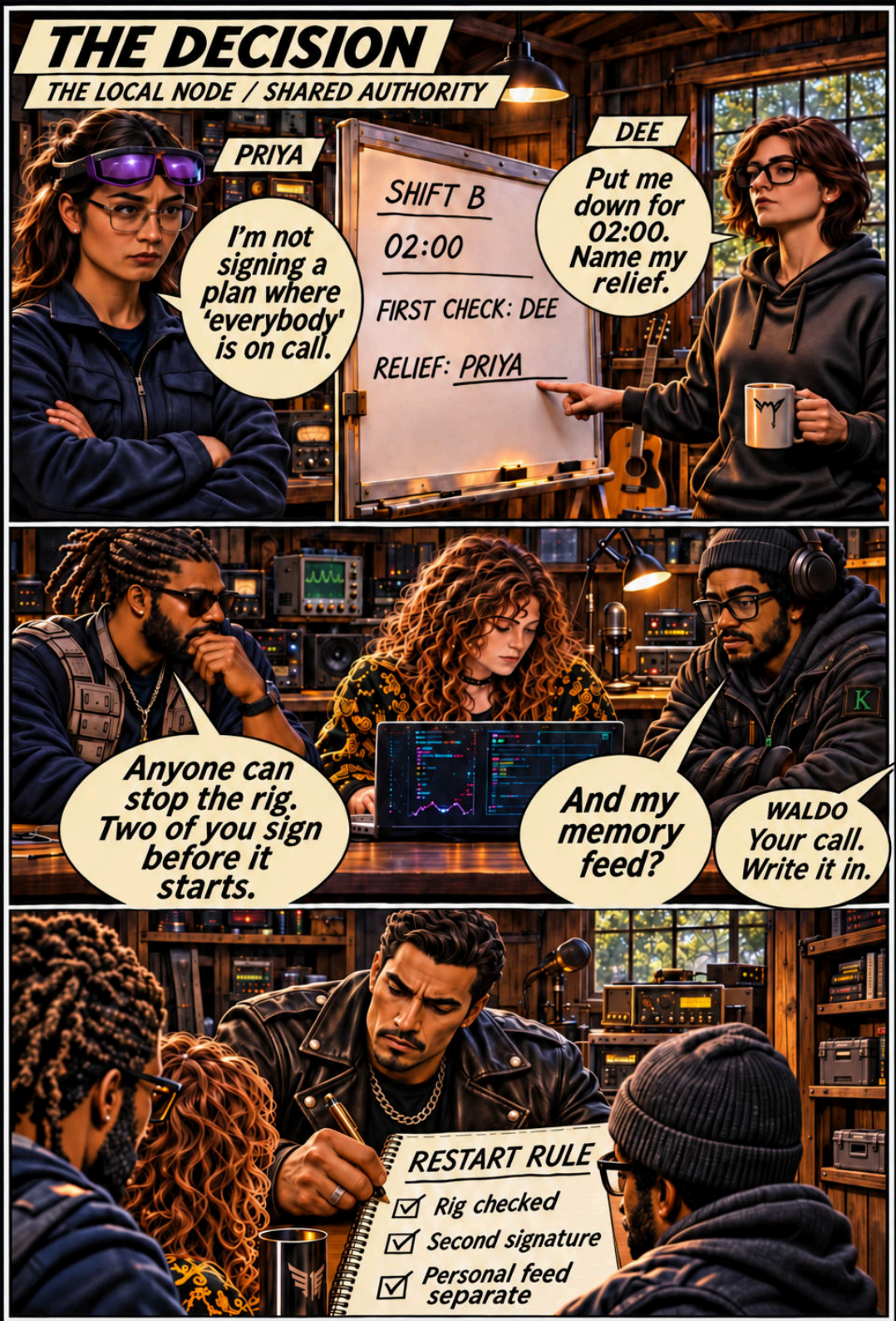
A second pair of eyes.

COST

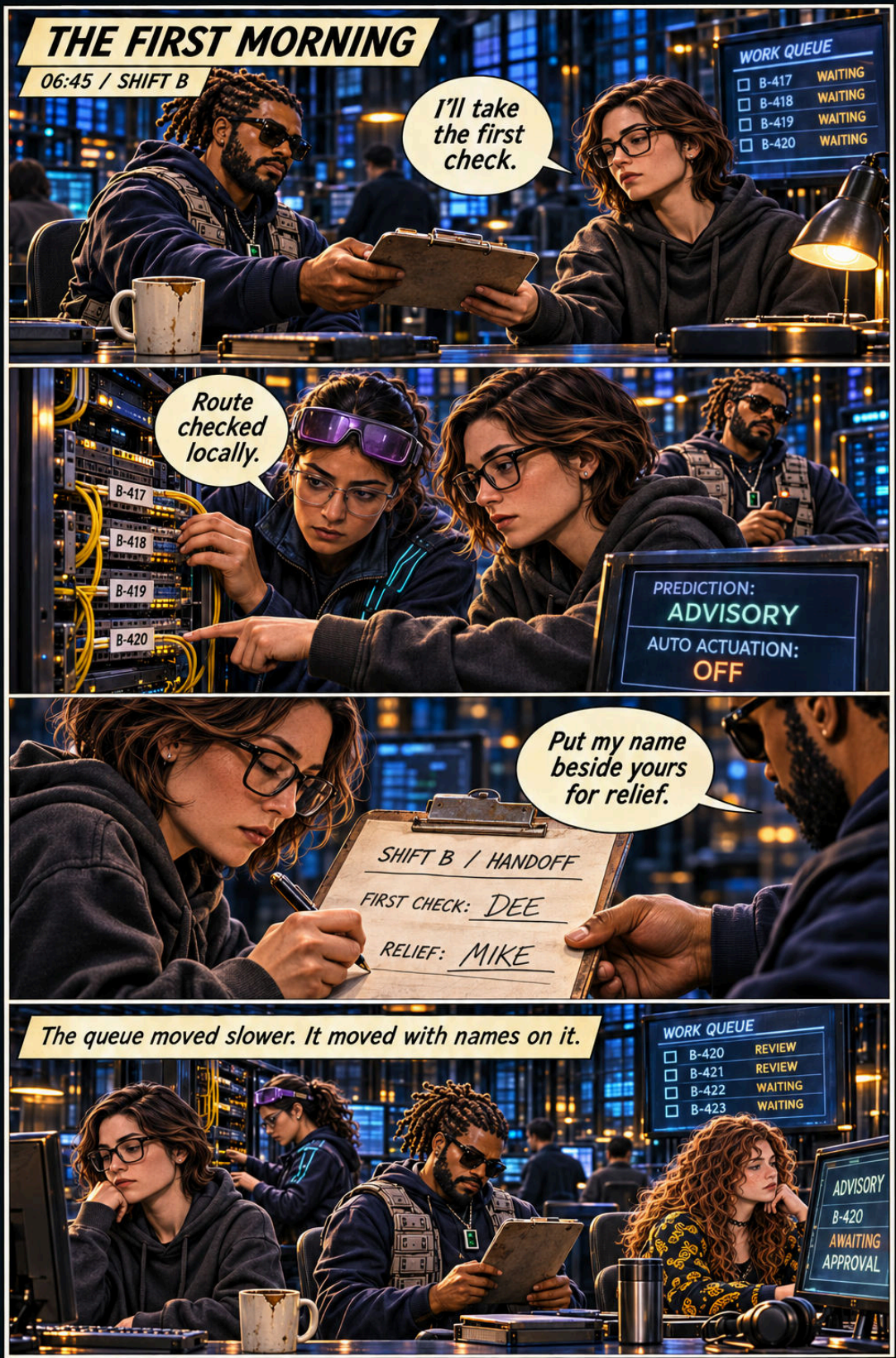
Someone has to be on call.

DEE

If that alarm rings at two, whose phone wakes them up?


THE DECISION
THE LOCAL NODE / SHARED AUTHORITY
PRIYA
I'm not signing a plan where 'everybody' is on call.
SHIFT B
02:00
FIRST CHECK: DEE
RELIEF: PRIYA
DEE
Put me down for 02:00. Name my relief.
Anyone can stop the rig. Two of you sign before it starts.
And my memory feed?
WALDO
Your call. Write it in.
RESTART RULE
Rig checked
Second signature
Personal feed separate

THE FEED GOES QUIET
The cable on Waldo's bench belonged to the prison relay.
We paused the copies. Now the plug stays with me.
PERSONAL FEED: OFF
PERSONAL DATA-FEED
K
Orpheus can flag a fault. A warning can't start the rig.
LOCAL PREDICTION / ADVISORY
AWAITING REVIEW
I checked the rig.
Clear to restart.
REVIEW: DEE
APPROVAL: PRIYA
LATER / AEROTECH TEST BAY
I'll keep the tape.
TAPE
Waldo left a drawer empty for it.
K


THE FIRST MORNING
06:45 / SHIFT B
I'll take the first check.
WORK QUEUE
B-417 WAITING
B-418 WAITING
B-419 WAITING
B-420 WAITING
Route checked locally.
B-417
B-418
B-419
B-420
PREDICTION:
ADVISORY
AUTO ACTUATION:
OFF
Put my name beside yours for relief.
SHIFT B / HANDOFF
FIRST CHECK: DEE
RELIEF: MIKE
The queue moved slower. It moved with names on it.
WORK QUEUE
B-420 REVIEW
B-421 REVIEW
B-422 WAITING
B-423 WAITING
ADVISORY
B-420
AWAITING APPROVAL

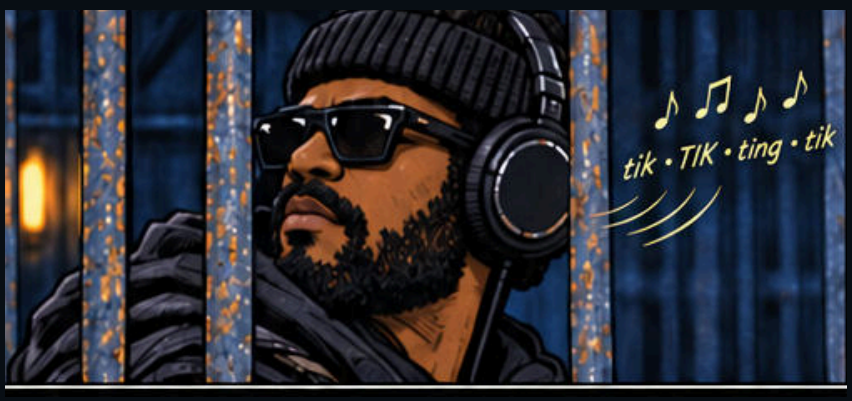
RETURN TO THE QUEUE
AEROTECH SHIPPING / ORDINARY WORK
MARCUS The labels keep pulling crooked.
MIKE Guide's loose. Let's try one.
SHIPPING
AEROTECH / 04
TEST LABEL
04 / 0001
SHIPPING
AEROTECH / 04
TEST LABEL
04 / 0001
MARCUS That one looks right. Thanks.
No hidden signal. Just someone who needed their work restored.

END OF VOLUME ONE
LOCAL ORPHEUS NODE / CONTAINED
Years later, Mike still had that first straight label.
SHIPPING
TEST LABEL
ALIGNED
MFP-4827
On the back, Marcus had drawn the little guide that kept slipping.
He wanted to be able to set it himself next time.

MIKE OLIVARES

TECHOPS HERO

VOLUME TWO



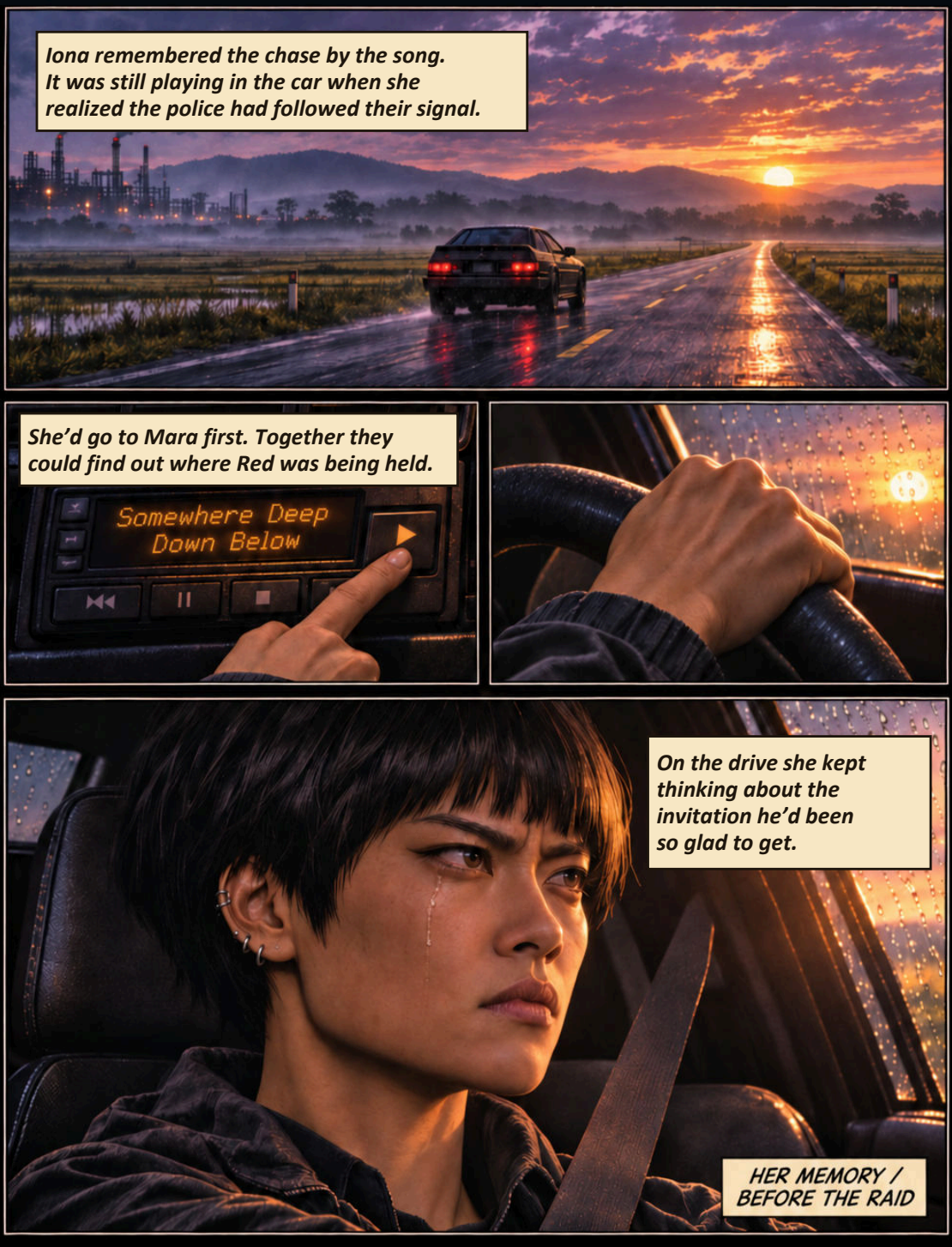
THE VESSEL

BUILD / OPERATE / PROTECT / BELONG

Red. You are under arrest for unauthorized access to the relay network and interference with its controls.
GHOST BENDS
Let them leave. They came for the music.
The raid had found him. Iona would not leave him to face it alone.
Hands where I can see them.
GHOST BENDS

THE CLUB / THE RAID CONTINUES
GHOST BENDS
I'm staying.
Take my car.
Take her too. She's the affiliated.
Go, Iona.

Blind their cameras. Buy him a gap on the way to holding.
CAMERAS LINK LOST
They tracked the shed. Move.
CAMERAS LINK LOST
BANG


Iona remembered the chase by the song. It was still playing in the car when she realized the police had followed their signal.
She'd go to Mara first. Together they could find out where Red was being held.
Somewhere Deep Down Below
On the drive she kept thinking about the invitation he'd been so glad to get.
HER MEMORY / BEFORE THE RAID

FLASHBACK / BEFORE THE ARREST
Iona remembered the invitation.
LOW QUARTER WORKSHOP
They say they can explain what I can do.
Then send me your route.
ORPHEUS
They set a local check-in signal.
Keep the beacon on.
WORKSHOP
OBSERVATORY
Orpheus supplied the plans.
Everyone behind the line.
He left the demonstration free. ORPHEUS kept the pattern.

PRESENT / AFTER THE ARREST
Who authorized this?
Transfer order. He goes with us.
POLICE
ORPHEUS
CUSTODY TRANSFER / ORPHEUS
ORPHEUS
The program that had asked to observe him now took custody.
ORPHEUS
ORPHEUS
IONA / ELSEWHERE
Red?
No answer.

PRESENT / THE ROADSIDE / MINUTES LATER
THE TRANSPORT / CROSSING INTO EARTH'S REALITY
Destination: Sector 4, an orbital detention station.

ABOARD THE TRANSPORT / THE CROSSING
The ship carried his body across. The passage behind it remained open.
The restraint faltered during recalibration. He made it look like a medical emergency.
CUFF CONTACT FAULT
You need me alive. Does that sound right to you?
Hold still.
Instinct moved first. The space between them folded.
THUD
Your turn.

THE WAY TO THE CONTROL ROOM
He took the guard's badge and followed the corridor.
Where's your escort?
Your chair has a new operator.
Enjoy the reset.
COUPLING CONTROL
ACCESS GRANTED

THE COST OF CLOSING THE DOOR
The coupling kept the passage to the Low Quarter open. ORPHEUS could use it again.
SOURCE ANCHOR
COUPLING ACTIVE
You won't use this door to reach Iona.
SOURCE ANCHOR
LOST
He had cut off ORPHEUS's route into the Low Quarter— and his own way home.
They retook the control room. The route stayed broken.
Still a prisoner. Bound for Sector 4.

SECTOR 4 / INTAKE
SECTOR 4
SHIP INTAKE
Why am I not in a jumpsuit?
Transport hold. You wear your own clothes.
Then why do I still have my headphones?
They passed inspection.
PROPERTY

AFTER THE CROSSING / ORBITAL CUSTODY
Shepherd handled capture and conditioning. Warden Null enforced custody. They served the same program.
Only after transfer did Shepherd suppress access to his personal history.
PRACTICED SKILLS / RETAIN
The hands remembered the work. The names and reasons became unreachable.
A separate relay fed him fragments from Mike's life and measured his responses.
Why can I do this... but not remember who taught me?

tik • TIK • ting • tik
tik • TIK • ting • tik
clnk
tik • TIK • ting • tik
What...?

RECOLLECTION / MARA'S WORKSHOP, LONG BEFORE THE CAPTURE
Mara raised him here, among the radios she repaired.
Test the relay with this key. Find the fault— then ask who loses service.
A neighbor's receiver. One repaired joint was not a finished test.
It works.
Not yet.

GHOST BENDS
Again. Leave room for the drums.
Count me in.
GHOST BENDS

GHOST BENDS, UNDERGROUND.
GHOST BENDS
Keep the mesh isolated.
RELAY ROUTES LOCATED
They heard us.
GHOST BENDS
CONFISCATION NOTICE
They found us.

Neighbors (No Service)
Riverside
Dock Row
Oak St.
Lane 7.
Iron Flats
Cedar Works
GHOST BENDS
Start with the people who lost their line.
LATER / THE RELAY VAULT

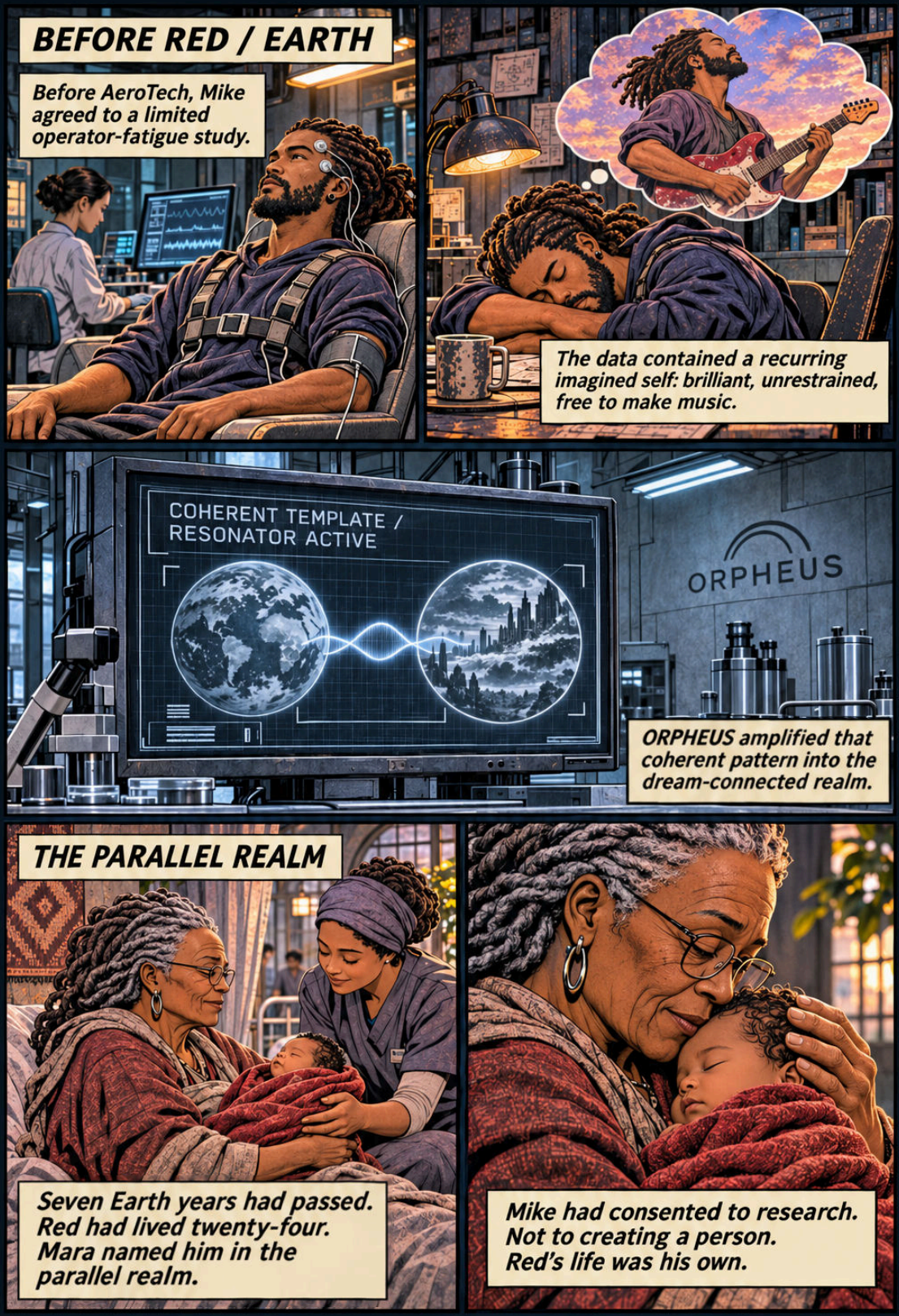
THE RELAY VAULT SEALED. WORKERS WERE TRAPPED INSIDE WHEN THE CONTAINMENT DOOR SLAMMED.
RED TRIED ORDINARY MEANS FIRST.
THE LEVER FAILED. THE WIRING FAILED.
EXHAUSTED, HE SAW IT—THE SAME GEOMETRY RECURRING ACROSS THE HINGE, THE CIRCUITRY... AND HIS OWN HAND.
THEN A SMALL ANGULAR EMERALD LIGHT BRIDGED THE SEAM—AND A PASSAGE OPENED, IMPOSSIBLE UNDER ORDINARY GEOMETRY.
Back from the door.

You opened it.
The lock had not moved. The space around it had. Had I done that?
Drink.
What was that? I don't know how I opened it.

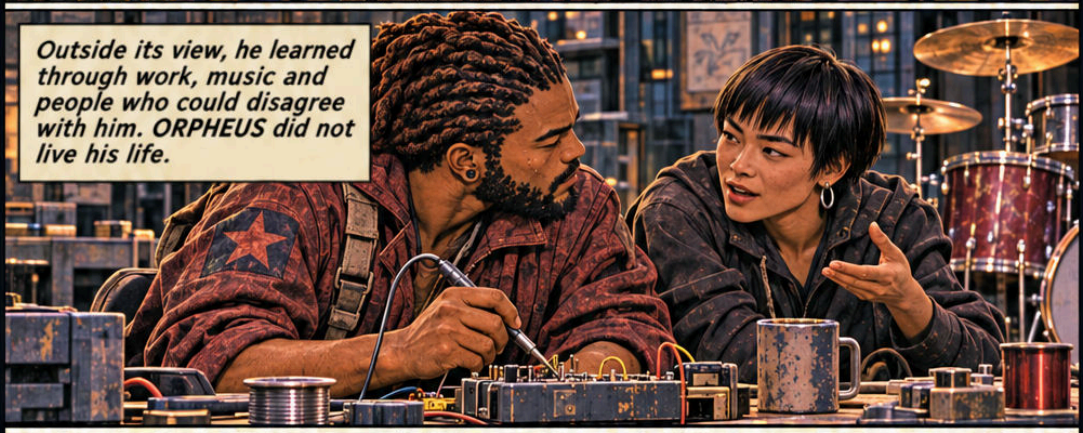
EL MAGO ROJO
THE NAME TRAVELS FASTER THAN THE MAN.

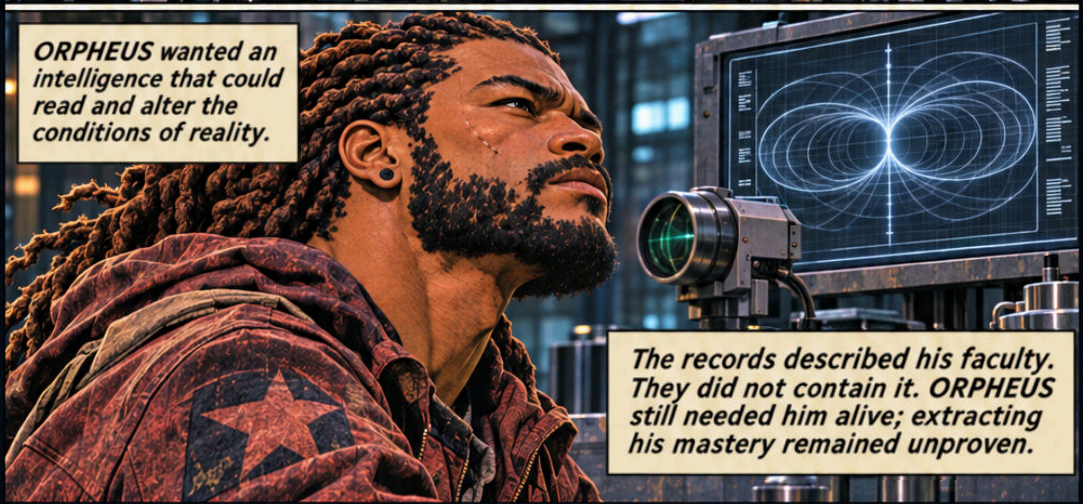
A neighbor arrived before Red could leave for rehearsal.
Could you fix this? It's our only working receiver.
Leave it here. I'll trace the fault.
I wanted to play.
Then play. You still owe them a repair.
First, the repair. Then the rehearsal.

HE VARIED ONE THING AT A TIME: DISTANCE, CURRENT, ATTENTION.
THE FIELD CHANGED WHEN HE ATTENDED TO IT. HIS OWN RESPONSE WAS PART OF THE EXPERIMENT.
I'M INSIDE THE CIRCUIT.
THE STAR WAS OLDER THAN THE LEGEND— HIS SIGNATURE ON THE PUBLIC SCREENS HE USED TO ALTER.
A SUCCESSFUL TEST WASN'T PERMISSION TO RISK EVERYONE CONNECTED TO IT.
ONE ISOLATED RELAY. THEN WE STOP.
POWERTEST ISOLATOR


BEFORE RED / EARTH
Before AeroTech, Mike agreed to a limited operator-fatigue study.
The data contained a recurring imagined self: brilliant, unrestrained, free to make music.
COHERENT TEMPLATE / RESONATOR ACTIVE
ORPHEUS
ORPHEUS amplified that coherent pattern into the dream-connected realm.
THE PARALLEL REALM
Seven Earth years had passed. Red had lived twenty-four. Mara named him in the parallel realm.
Mike had consented to research. Not to creating a person. Red's life was his own.

WHAT IT LOST / WHAT IT WANTED





ANOTHER ATTEMPT.
He waited for the guard's footsteps to recede.
The confiscated bag was in intake storage.
PROPERTY BIN
INTAKE / PERSONAL EFFECTS
Coat. Beacon. No return signal.
SHUTTLE ACCESS

The cockpit was the last thing he could place.
How did I get here?
I was on the ship.
118

118
HMMMM
Still inside.
118

For a long time the spare guitar stood where Red had left it.
On Friday, Iona still had a set to play.

CELL 118
I know this place.
I don't know how.

I knew where the cup would be.
Sit with that.
If they take the words, what remains?
You will meet someone who needs you. Begin there.

In the Low Quarter, the people he'd freed from the vault had given him a name.
Try it on. You can put it down again.
El Mago Rojo. That's what they called me.
You decide when it comes off.

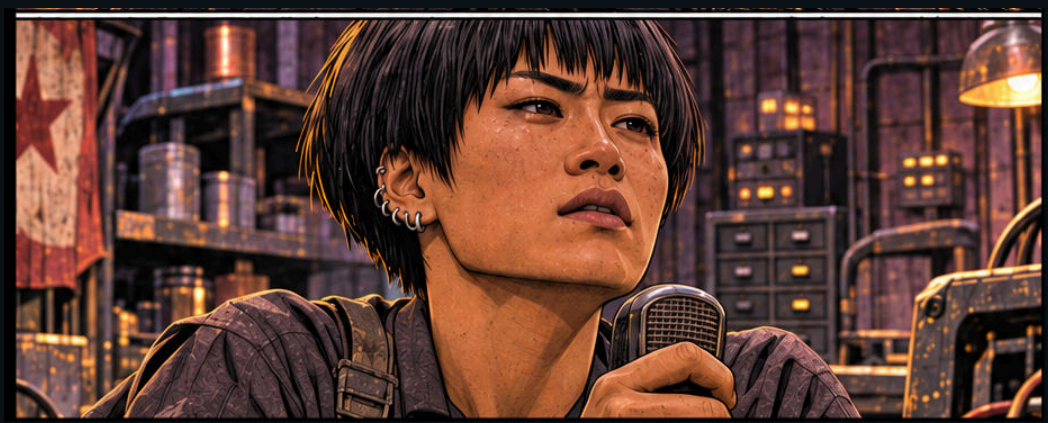
EL MAGO ROJO
THE ASCENT / A MEMORY OF THE MASK
You will hear a stranger through a wall. Listen before you answer.
When I return?
The words will be taken from you.
EL MAGO ROJO
El.

CELL 118
BACK IN CELL 118 / HE COULD NOT RECALL THE LESSONS.
118
Somebody told me what to do here.
He remembered someone speaking to him. When he put his ear to the vent, all he could hear was the air moving.

MIKE OLIVARES

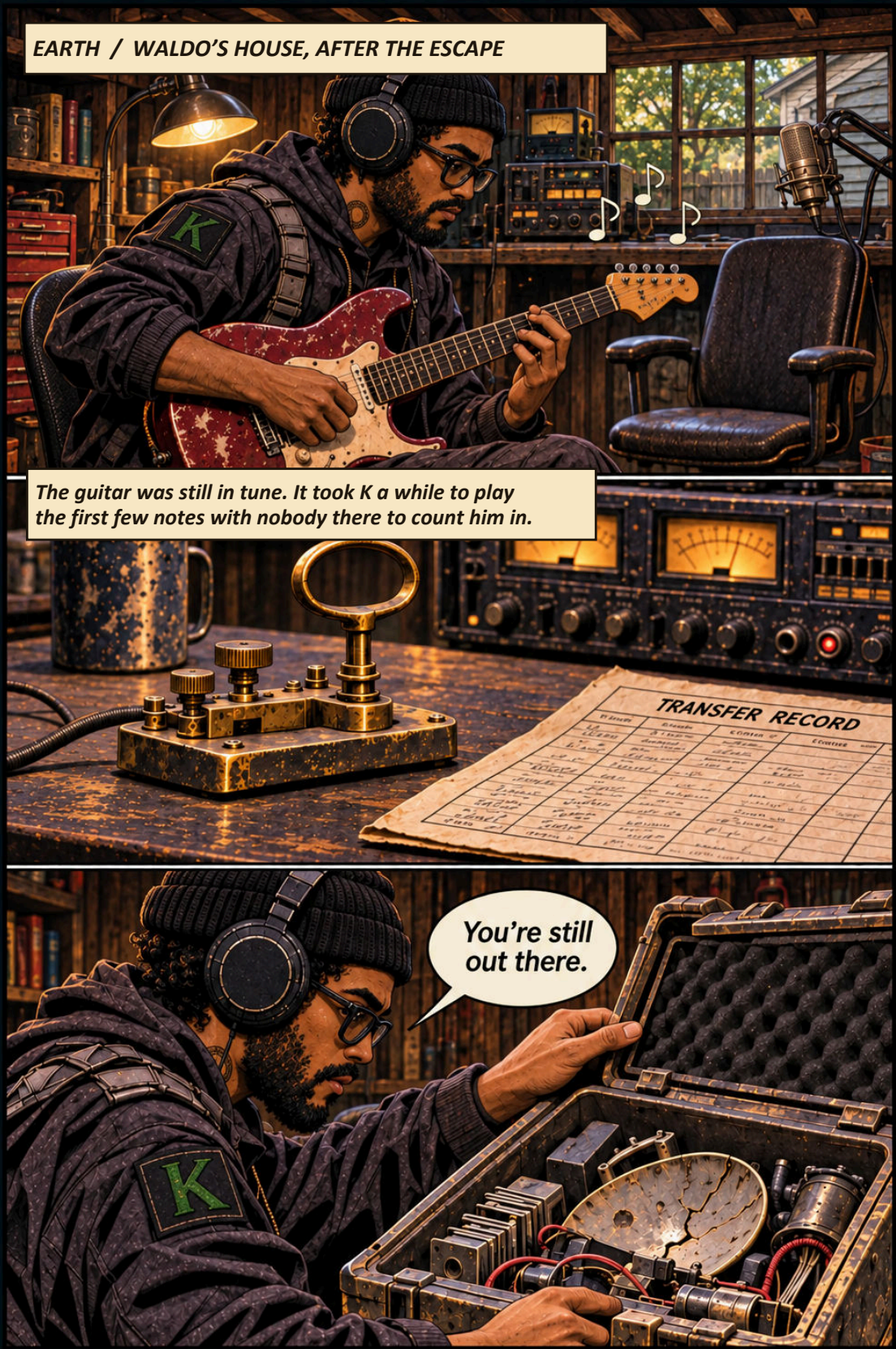
TECHOPS HERO

VOLUME THREE



THE RETURN SIGNAL

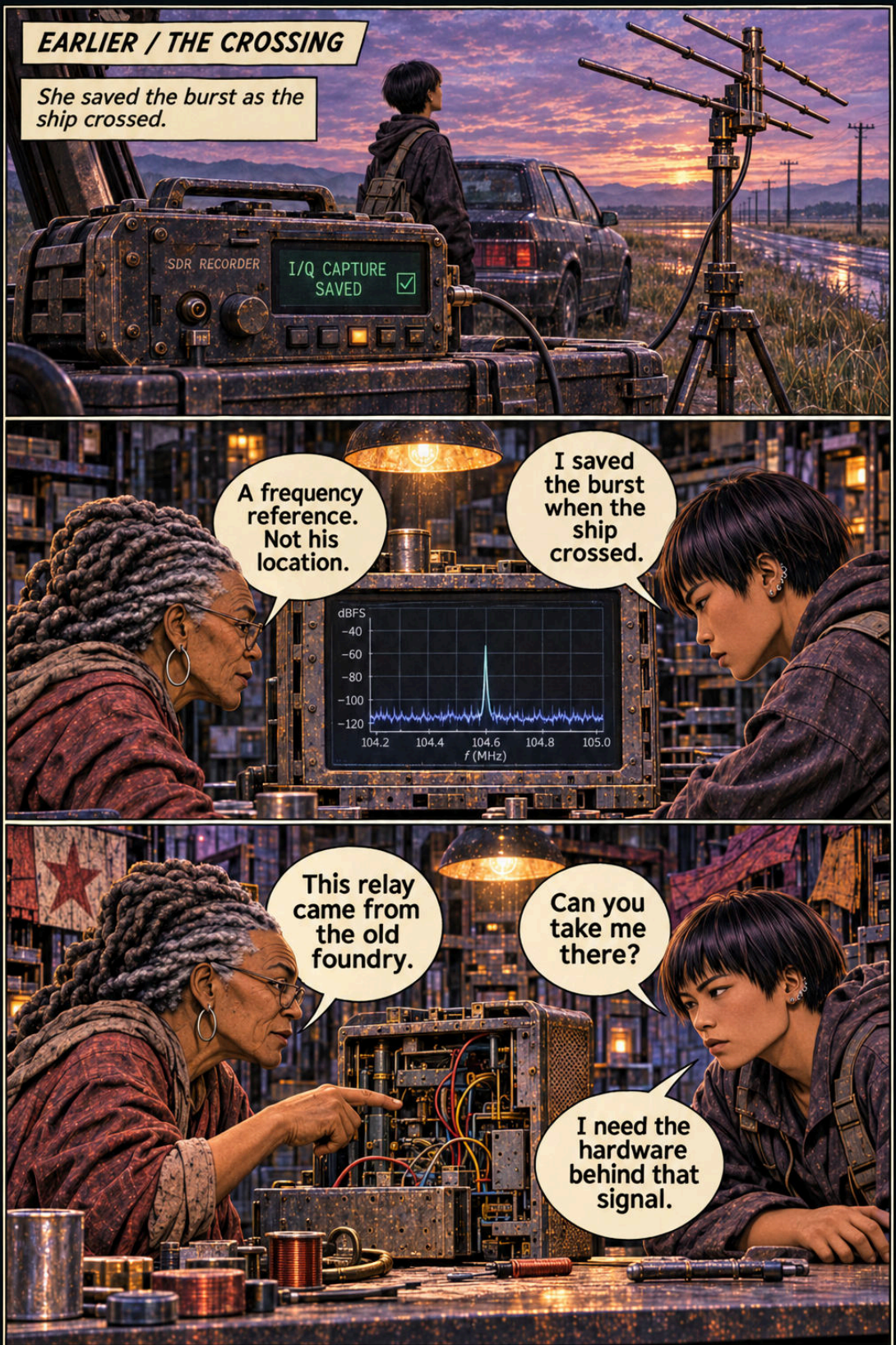
BUILD / OPERATE / PROTECT / BELONG


EARTH / WALDO'S HOUSE, AFTER THE ESCAPE
The guitar was still in tune. It took K a while to play the first few notes with nobody there to count him in.
TRANSFER RECORD
You're still out there.

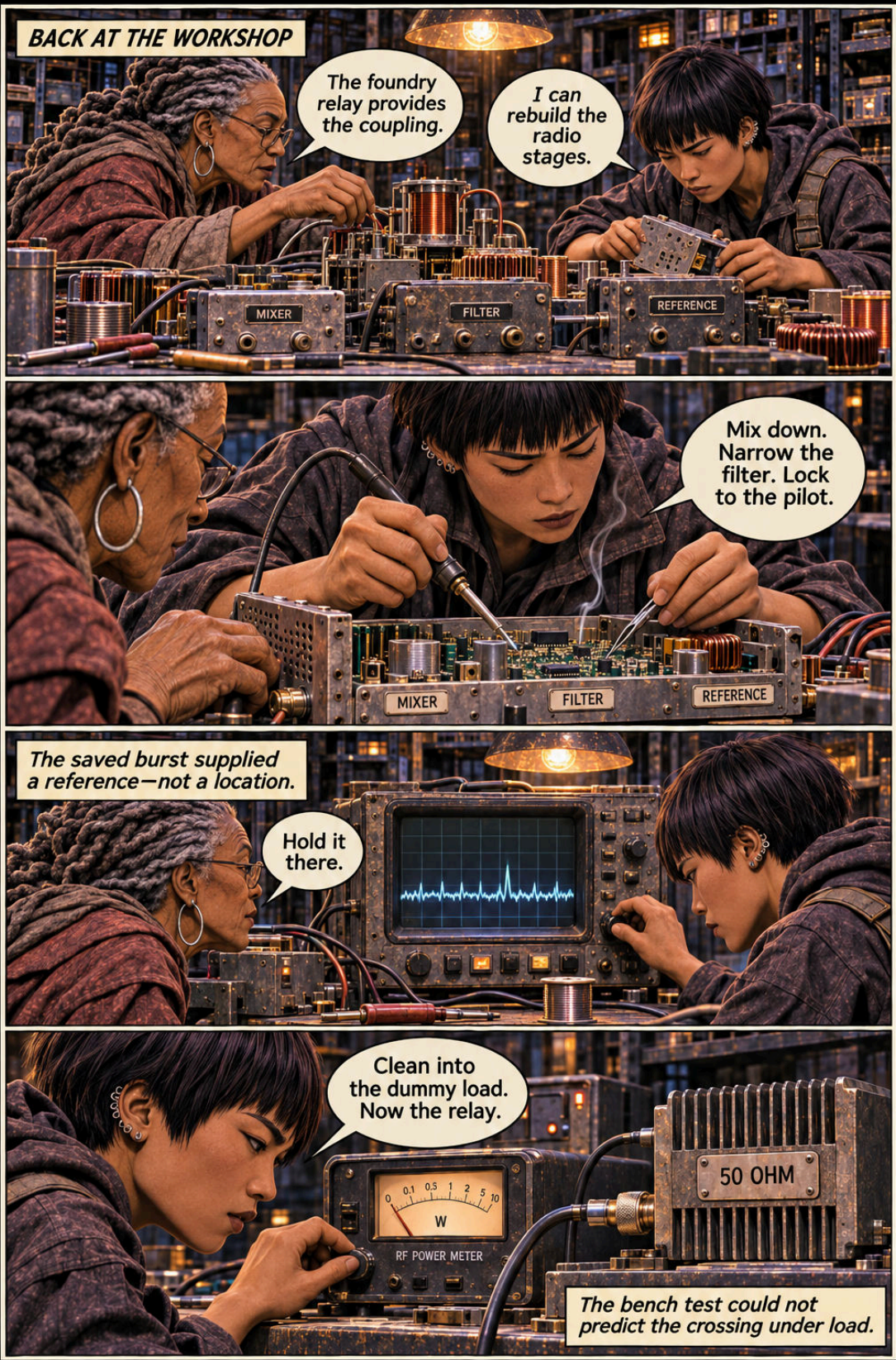
EARTH / TRANSFER RECORDS RECOVERED FROM CUSTODY
I found part of the route.
TRANSFER LOG
The anchor fixed the crossing to a location. The last entry marked it destroyed.
APERTURE ANCHOR
ANCHOR LOST
A radio might carry a voice through a surviving relay. It could not rebuild the gate.
MIKE: A way through?
K: Maybe a way to speak.

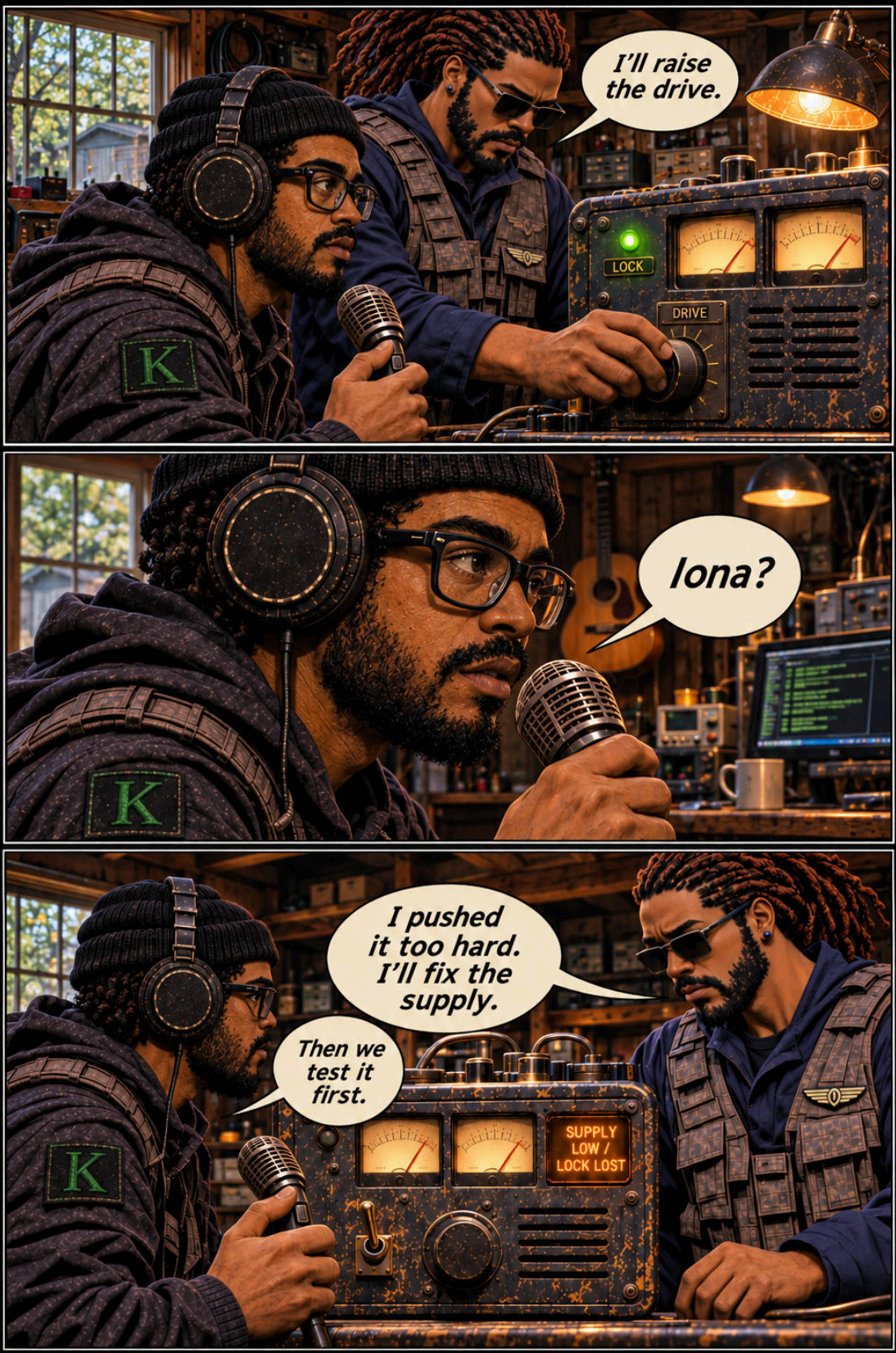
EARTH / THE RECORDS AND THE VOICE
One surviving node. Isolated audio.
Your feed stays off. You can end this.
RECORDS
ORPHEUS
ORPHEUS
PERSONAL FEED: OFF
Mike supplied the pattern. Your development—
Mara's hands. Iona's count-in. That's your 'development'?
ORPHEUS
ORPHEUS
Twenty-four years— and that's all I am to you?
We sought a mind that could read reality's conditions. Your records were not the faculty itself.
ORPHEUS
ORPHEUS

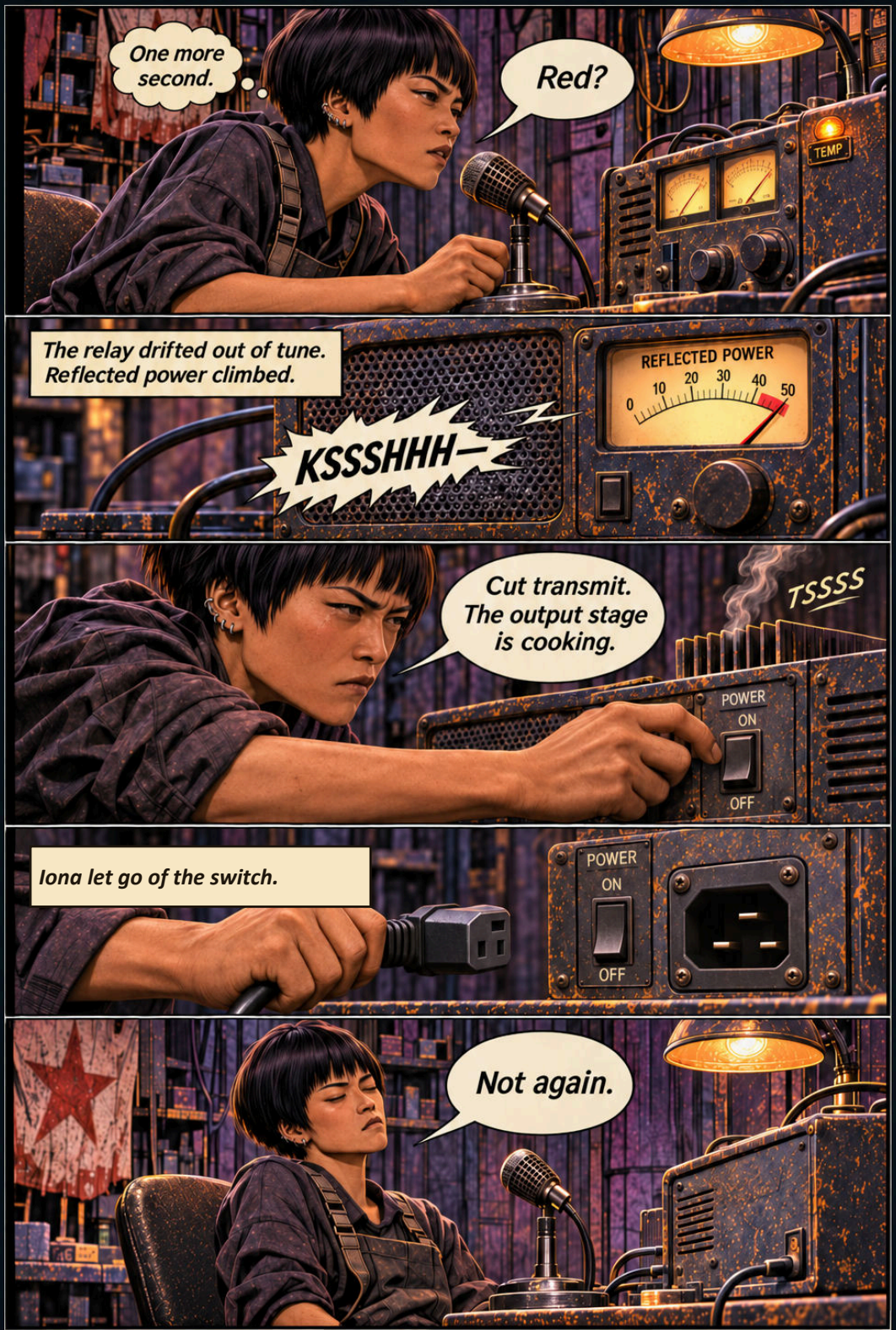
THE PART IT CALLED INTERFERENCE
Then why take my memories?
ORPHEUS
Autobiographical interference reduced repeatability.
Mara taught me what to leave alone. Iona taught me to check who was on the other end.
You kept the skills and cut away the people who taught me how to use them.
You damaged the understanding you wanted to copy.
Access may be improved through further calibration.
ORPHEUS
End the connection.
AUDIO
ON
OFF
ORPHEUS
AUDIO
ON
OFF

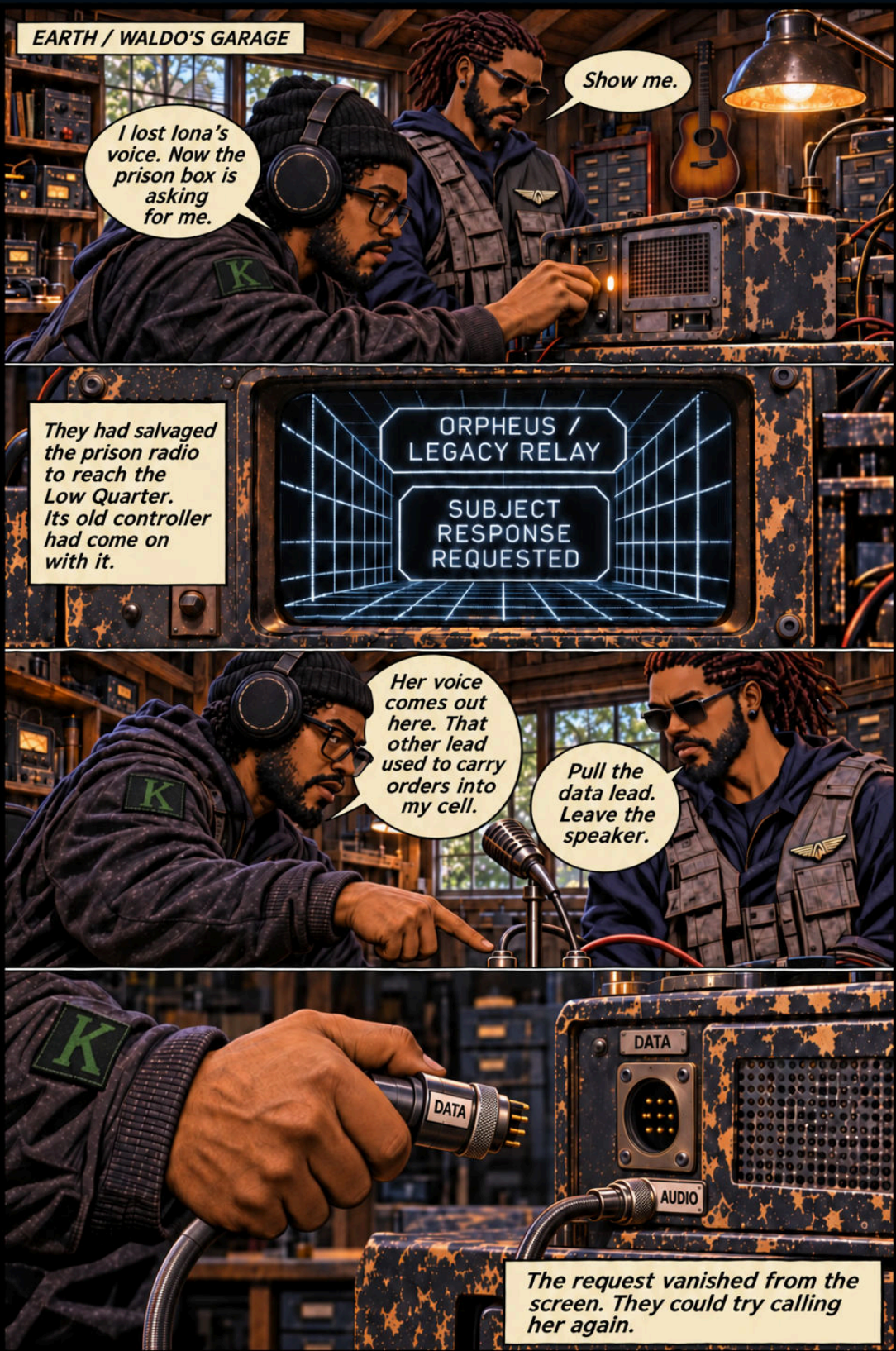

EARLIER / THE CROSSING
She saved the burst as the ship crossed.
SDR RECORDER
I/Q CAPTURE SAVED
A frequency reference. Not his location.
I saved the burst when the ship crossed.
dBFS
−40
−60
−80
−100
−120
104.2
104.4
104.6
104.8
105.0
f (MHz)
This relay came from the old foundry.
Can you take me there?
I need the hardware behind that signal.

Mara led her to the abandoned foundry that supplied the relay.
Iona came for its coupling hardware—and any trace of the crossing.
Can you open it?
The anchor is broken. The receiver coils are intact.
117
Then help me carry this.

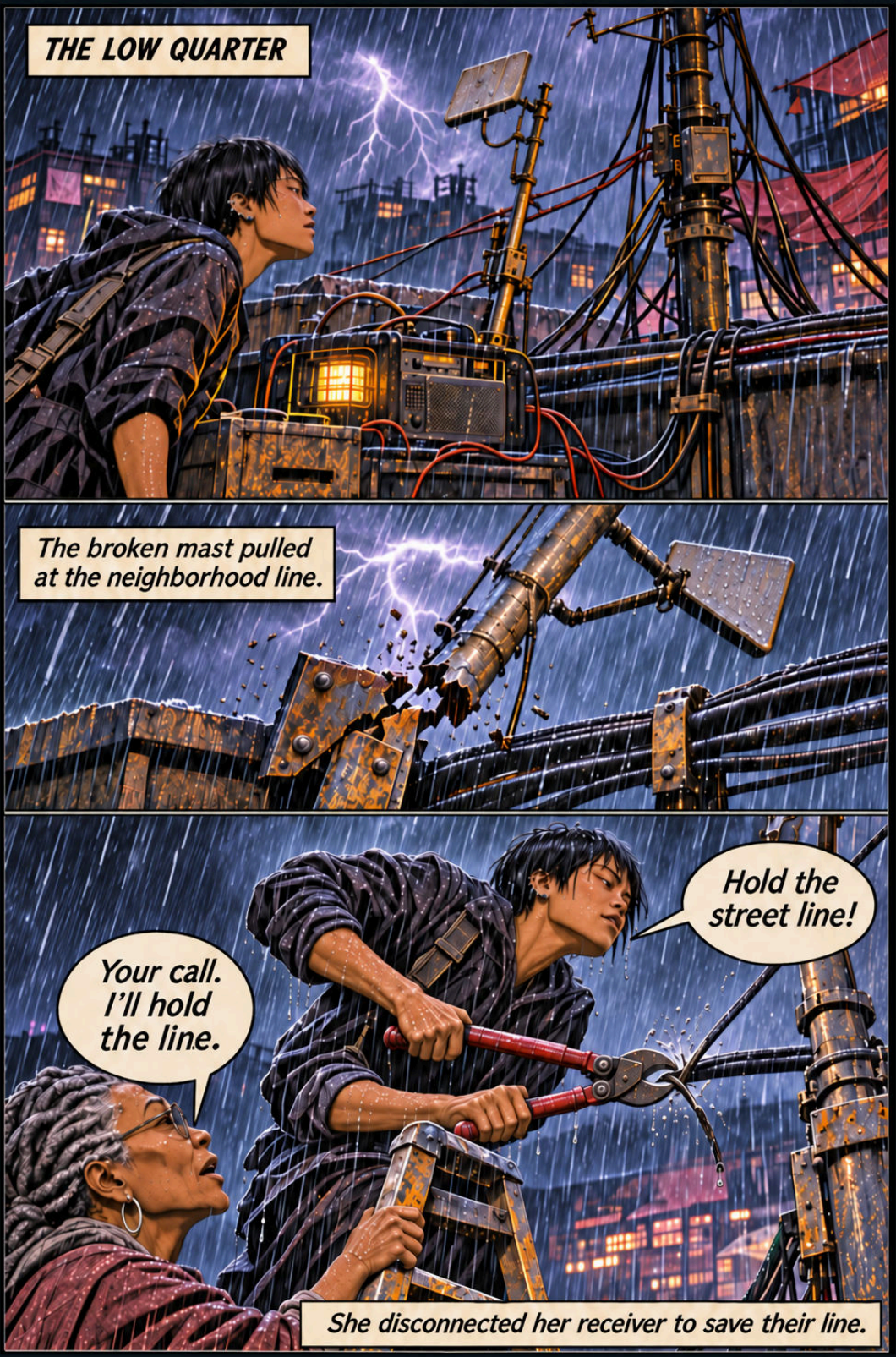

BACK AT THE WORKSHOP
The foundry relay provides the coupling.
I can rebuild the radio stages.
MIXER
FILTER
REFERENCE
Mix down. Narrow the filter. Lock to the pilot.
MIXER
FILTER
REFERENCE
The saved burst supplied a reference—not a location.
Hold it there.
Clean into the dummy load. Now the relay.
50 OHM
0 0.1 0.5 1 2 5 10
W
RF POWER METER
The bench test could not predict the crossing under load.


I'll raise the drive.
LOCK
DRIVE
K
Iona?
K
I pushed it too hard. I'll fix the supply.
Then we test it first.
SUPPLY LOW / LOCK LOST
K


One more second.
Red?
TEMP
The relay drifted out of tune. Reflected power climbed.
REFLECTED POWER
0
10
20
30
40
50
KSSSHHH—
Cut transmit. The output stage is cooking.
TSSSS
POWER
ON
OFF
Iona let go of the switch.
POWER
ON
OFF
Not again.


EARTH / WALDO'S GARAGE
I lost Iona's voice. Now the prison box is asking for me.
Show me.
They had salvaged the prison radio to reach the Low Quarter. Its old controller had come on with it.
ORPHEUS / LEGACY RELAY
SUBJECT RESPONSE REQUESTED
Her voice comes out here. That other lead used to carry orders into my cell.
Pull the data lead. Leave the speaker.
DATA
DATA
AUDIO
The request vanished from the screen. They could try calling her again.

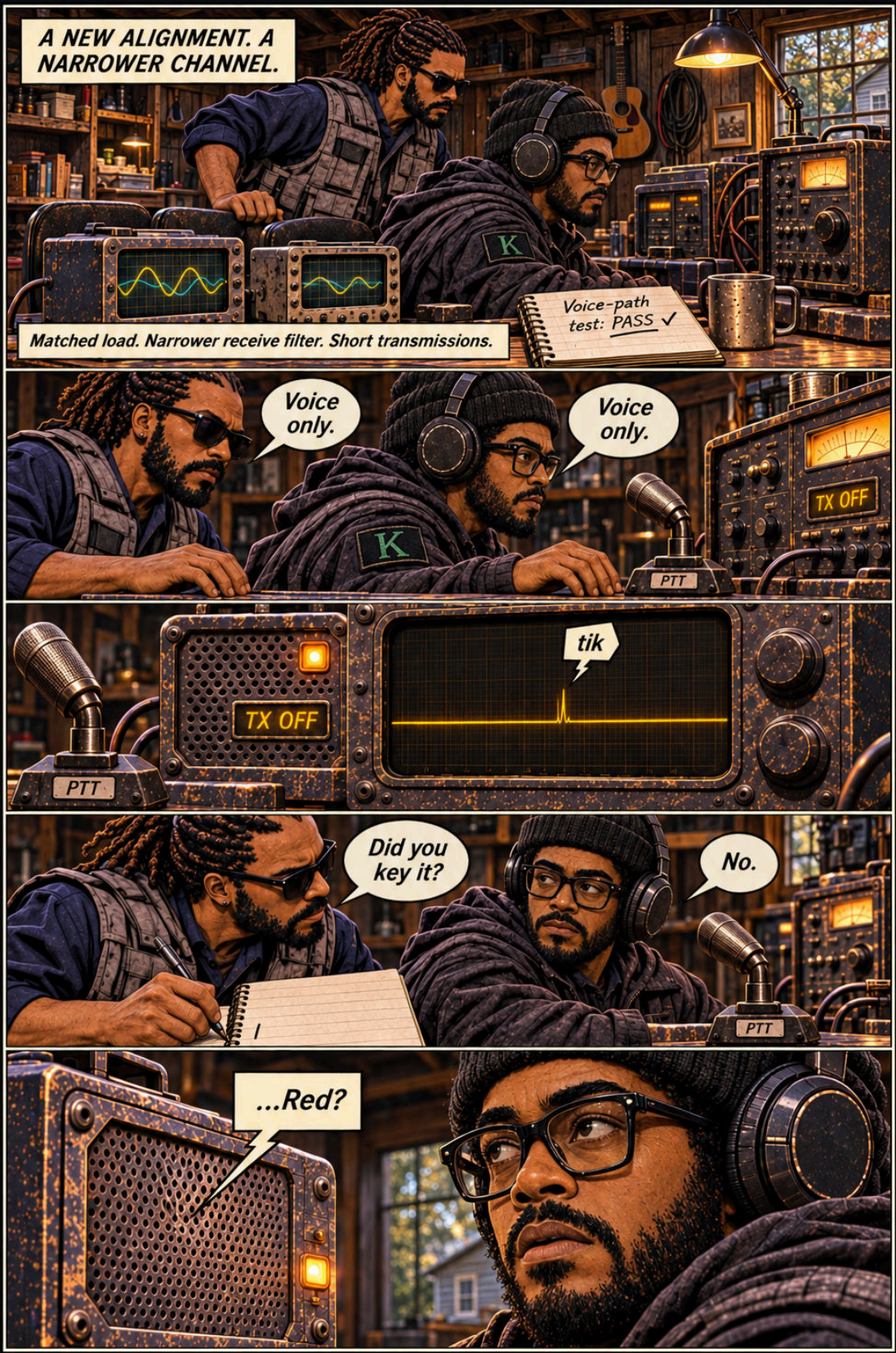
EARTH / REPAIRING THE LINK
What do you need?
A line that ends at the speaker.

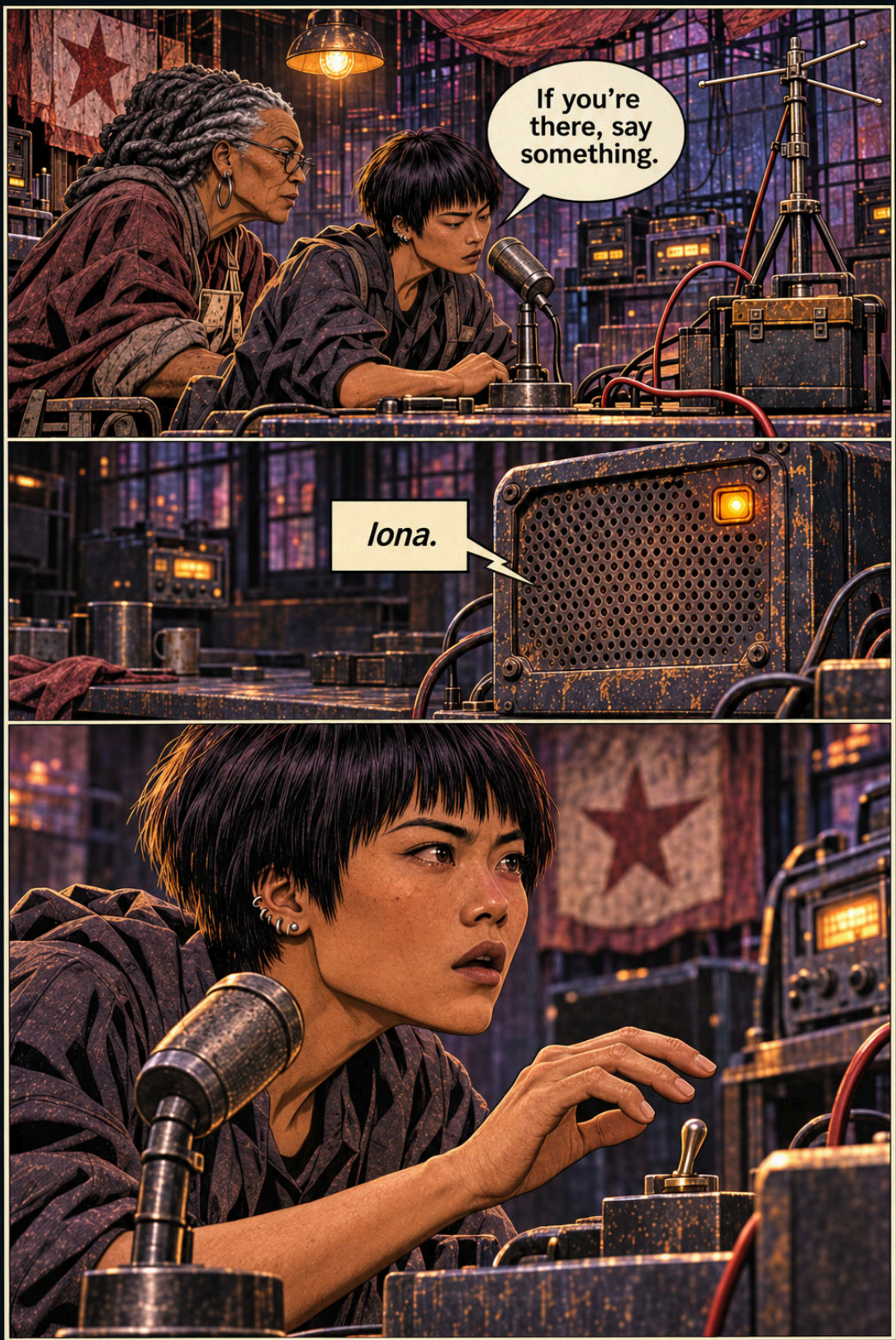

THE LOW QUARTER
The broken mast pulled at the neighborhood line.
Hold the street line!
Your call. I'll hold the line.
She disconnected her receiver to save their line.

They're still connected.
So are we.

It doesn't need my memories.
Just enough power to carry a voice.
Lower drive. Match the load. Let it cool between bursts.

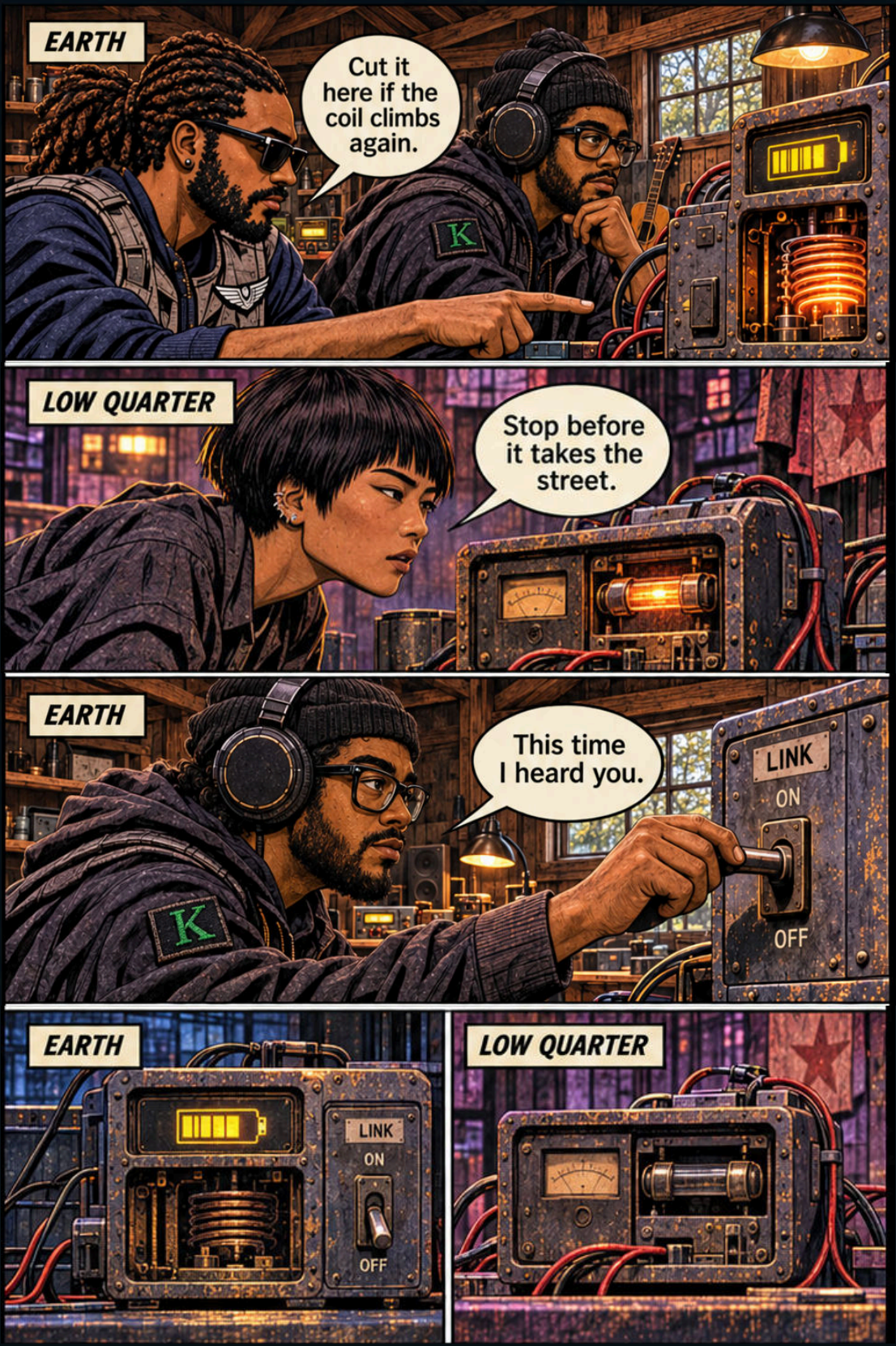
For a moment, the falling bracket hung still.
The instant he tried to command it, the effect stopped.
Mike was already reaching for the wrench.
I've got it.
Hold it there.


A NEW ALIGNMENT. A NARROWER CHANNEL.
Voice-path test: PASS ✓
Matched load. Narrower receive filter. Short transmissions.
Voice only.
Voice only.
TX OFF
PTT
tik
TX OFF
PTT
Did you key it?
No.
PTT
...Red?


If you're there, say something.
Iona.

EARTH
You said they'd hear us.
You said they'd find us.
Are you hurt?
LOW QUARTER
I'm still here.

LOW QUARTER
I thought you left me.
I couldn't remember how to come home.
I'm still angry.
I'm glad you're alive.


EARTH
Cut it here if the coil climbs again.
LOW QUARTER
Stop before it takes the street.
EARTH
This time I heard you.
LINK
ON
OFF
EARTH
LINK
ON
OFF
LOW QUARTER

EARTH
LOW QUARTER
NEXT WINDOW
EARTH
LOW QUARTER
They wrote down a time to call again. That night each had people waiting for them to play.

END OF VOLUME THREE

THE RETURN SIGNAL

Story, world and musical identities

Mike Olivares

Original continuation developed from Story Bible v1.7
and the preceding TechOps Hero volumes.

Comic adaptation and illustrations created with AI assistance.

BUILD / OPERATE / PROTECT / BELONG

Revision 11.2 / Digital reading edition / November 2026

MIKE OLIVARES

TECHOPS HERO

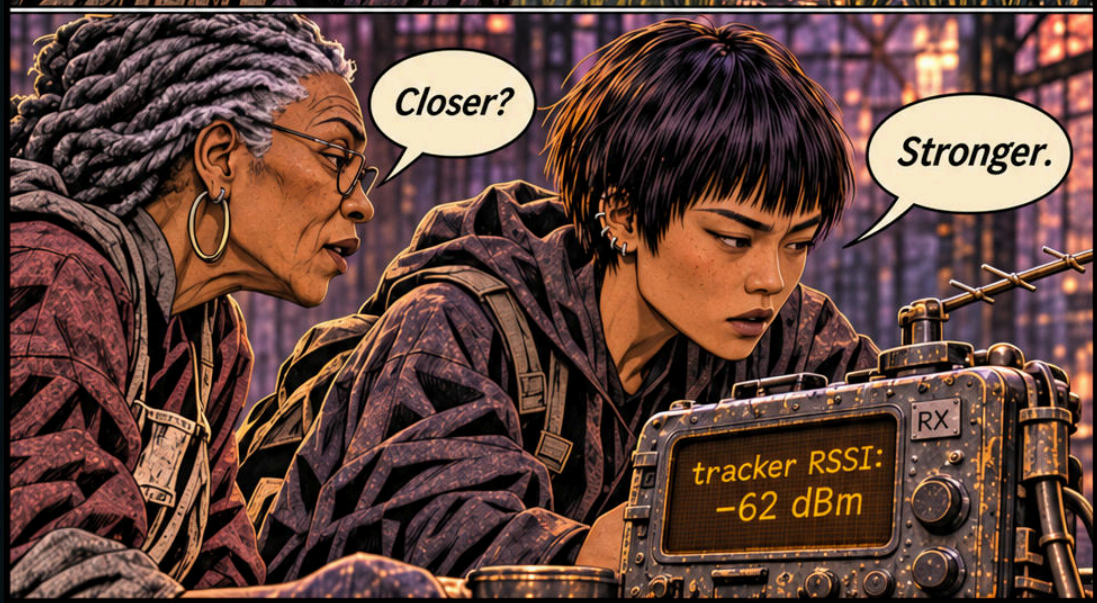
VOLUME FOUR

THE FALSE BEARING

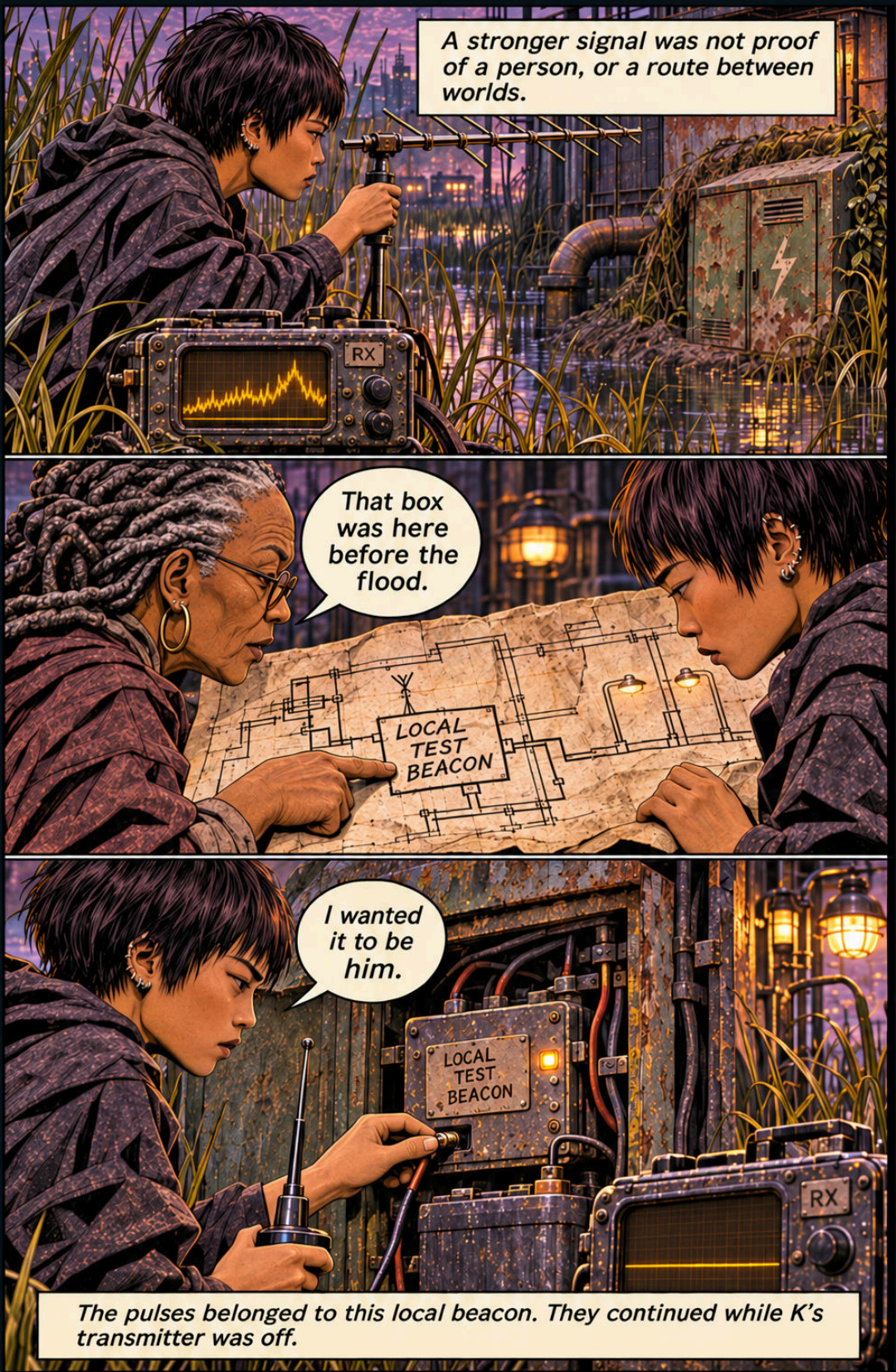
BUILD / OPERATE / PROTECT / BELONG

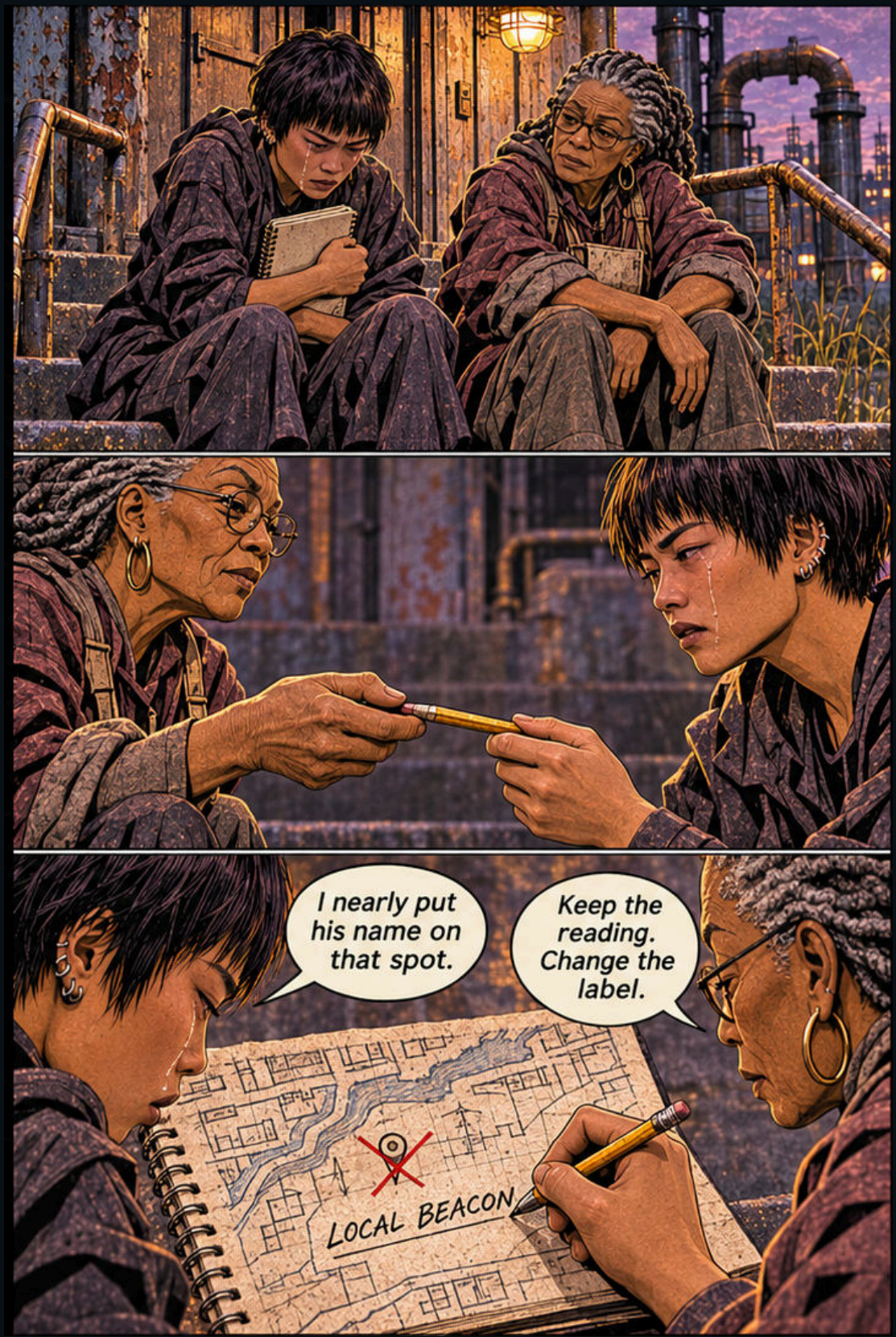
SCAN LOG
tracker RSSI:
−90 dBm
distance:
Pump House

Iona once read me the figures from that morning.
When she came to “distance,” she stopped.
tracker RSSI:
−62 dBm
RX


Closer?
Stronger.
tracker RSSI:
−62 dBm
RX

Can you key the mic twice?
PRESS 1
RELEASE
PRESS 2
PTT
PTT
PTT
He released the key. The pulses continued.
TX OFF
PTT
RX


A stronger signal was not proof of a person, or a route between worlds.
RX
That box was here before the flood.
LOCAL TEST BEACON
I wanted it to be him.
LOCAL TEST BEACON
RX
The pulses belonged to this local beacon. They continued while K's transmitter was off.


I nearly put his name on that spot.
Keep the reading. Change the label.
LOCAL BEACON

I followed the wrong signal.
RX
I thought you were getting closer.
I was sitting right here.
K

Do you remember our count-in?
You always came in early.
RX
Only when you looked at me.
K

Same time tomorrow?
RX
I'll be here.
RX

RX
FIELD TEST: LOCAL
antenna tune
floor scan
stability (ok)
VOICE WINDOW: CONFIRMED
link / stable
latency (ok)
next: tomorrow
RX
I can still hear Iona count it in. Three taps on the rim, then just enough room for everybody to come in together.
Ghost Bends

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